



AMERICAN PREVIEW



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

	1	NAVY MIDSHIPMEN
	2	MEMPHIS TIGERS
	3	UTSA ROADRUNNERS
	4	ARMY BLACK KNIGHTS
	5	EAST CAROLINA PIRATES
	6	SOUTH FLORIDA BULLS
	7	TULANE GREEN WAVE
	8	TEMPLE OWLS
	9	FLORIDA ATLANTIC OWLS
	10	TULSA GOLDEN HURRICANE
	11	NORTH TEXAS MEAN GREEN
	12	RICE OWLS
	13	UAB BLAZERS
	14	CHARLOTTE 49ERS

AMERICAN CHAMPIONSHIP

NAVY OVER MEMPHIS



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT ATHLONSports.com FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-AMERICAN CONFERENCE TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	OWEN McCOWN	UTSA
RB	JAHIEM WHITE	North Texas
RB	JAMAURI McCCLURE	Tulane
AP	WILL HENDERSON III	UTSA
WR	EASTON MESSER	Florida Atlantic
WR	DAVID AMADOR II	UTSA
WR	BROCK SPALDING	East Carolina
TE	PETER CLARKE	Temple
C	BRADY SMALL	Army
OL	ADAM LEPKOWSKI	UAB
OL	CAM NICHOLS	Navy
OL	ERIC KING	Temple
OL	VINCENT FIACABLE	Florida Atlantic

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	J'MOND TAPP	Memphis
DL	CJ DOGGETTE JR.	Florida Atlantic
DL	JACK BOUSUM	Army
DL	JASIAH ROBINSON	East Carolina
LB	MARCANTHONY PARKER	Navy
LB	LEON HART JR.	Florida Atlantic
LB	CURLY ORDONEZ	Temple
LB	MIKE MONTGOMERY	Memphis
DB	ELIJAH GREEN	Tulsa
DB	ZACH WILLIAMS	Tulsa
DB	JACK TCHIENCHOU	Tulane
DB	IAN FOSTER	Memphis

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	NICO GRAMATICA	South Florida
P	CAILE HOGAN	UTSA
KR	JAYLIN LUCAS	Tulane
PR	EASTON MESSER	Florida Atlantic

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Cure: East Carolina vs. Western Michigan

Xbox: Old Dominion vs. Utah State

Gasparilla: Memphis vs. Georgia Tech

Puerto Rico: South Florida vs. Fresno State

Military: Temple vs. Wake Forest

Fenway: Army vs. NC State

New Mexico: UTSA vs. New Mexico

Armed Forces: Navy vs. Arizona State

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

ARMY

Defense: New: Daryl Dixon, Scot Sloan
Old: Nate Woody

EAST CAROLINA

Offense: New: Jordan Davis
Old: John David Baker
Defense: New: Jordon Hankins, Roy Tesh; Old: Josh Aldridge

MEMPHIS

Offense: New: Kevin Decker, David Weeks; Old: Tim Cramsey
Defense: New: Lance Guidry
Old: Jordon Hankins

NAVY

Defense: New: Eric Lewis, Ricky Brown
Old: P.J. Volker

NORTH TEXAS

Offense: New: Neal Brown
Old: Jordan Davis
Defense: New: Matt Powledge, Bradley Dale Peveto; Old: Skyler Cassity

SOUTH FLORIDA

Offense: New: Tim Beck
Old: Kodi Burns, Joel Gordon
Defense: New: Josh Aldridge
Old: Todd Orlando

TULANE

Offense: New: Russ Callaway
Old: Joe Craddock
Defense: New: Tayler Polk, Nate Fuqua
Old: Greg Gasparato

TULSA

Offense: New: Kevin Barbay, Ty Darling; Old: Brad Robbins

UAB

Defense: New: Todd Grantham
Old: Steve Russ

UTSA

Offense: New: Rick Bowie
Old: Justin Burke

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Tylan George	IOL	Tulane	★★★	466
2. Jordyn Crites	DL	Tulane	★★★	469
3. Jamarcea Plater	RB	Tulsa	★★★	599
4. Elijah Fernandez	LB	Memphis	★★★	668
5. Terande Spencer	EDGE	East Carolina	★★★	698



OWEN McCOWN, UTSA
MIKE MONTGOMERY, MEMPHIS



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. J'Mond Tapp	DL	Memphis	Southern Miss Tapp racked up 7.5 sacks and earned all-conference honors last season in the Sun Belt.
2. Jahiem White	RB	North Texas	West Virginia White has big-play potential and Power 4 conference experience.
3. Michael Van Buren Jr.	QB	South Florida	LSU Van Buren started a dozen games in the SEC; his best football may still be ahead of him.
4. C.J. Hicks	DL	South Florida	Ohio State Hicks is a Big Ten veteran who could make an impact off the edge for the Bulls.
5. Ian Foster	DB	Memphis	Southern Miss Foster is a ball hawk who's on his third Charles Huff-coached team in three seasons.
6. Kyran Duhon	DL	Tulsa	Oklahoma State Duhon will try to return to his freshman form, when he racked up seven sacks at UTEP.
7. Marcus Stokes	QB	Memphis	West Florida Stokes was named a finalist for the Div. II Harlon Hill Trophy.
8. Ashton Gray	RB	East Carolina	North Texas He made the most of his touches last season before he ran wild in North Texas' bowl game.
9. Zeon Chriss-Gremillion	QB	Tulane	Houston Chriss-Gremillion returns to the state of Louisiana armed with starting experience.
10. Jaxon Smolik	QB	Temple	Penn State Smolik gets his first shot at starting in head coach K.C. Keeler's offense.

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. Temple (65)	5. East Carolina (94)	9. Charlotte (108)
2. Tulane (67)	6. Rice (99)	10. Florida Atlantic (119)
3. UTSA (79)	7. South Florida (103)	11. UAB (133)
4. Memphis (82)	8. Tulsa (104)	12. Navy (134)
		13. Army (136)
		14. North Texas (140)

Rankings per Rivals; National ranking in parentheses

GAMES TO WATCH

Aug. 29 Memphis at UNLV	Oct. 31 Navy vs. Notre Dame (Foxborough, MA)
Sept. 12 Memphis at Boise State	Nov. 21 Memphis at Navy
Sept. 12 South Florida at Army	Nov. 21 East Carolina at Army
Oct. 8 South Florida at UTSA	Nov. 27 Tulane at South Florida
Oct. 17 Navy at UTSA	Dec. 12 Army vs. Navy (East Rutherford, NJ)
Oct. 22 East Carolina at Memphis	
Oct. 24 UTSA at Tulane	

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Jude Okeleke	DL	Temple	★★★	709
7. Jordan Harrison	IOL	South Florida	★★★	805
8. Aiden Martin	OT	Tulane	★★★	860
9. Eric Perry	RB	Memphis	★★★	898
10. Asaad Chapman	CB	UTSA	★★★	10*

*Rankings per Rivals industry ranking; *Junior college transfer/JUCO ranking*



ARMY BLACK KNIGHTS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 7-6 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-4 AMERICAN

OFFENSE How does quarterback Cale Hellums top his 2025 season? Hellums, who was third on the preseason depth chart, finished second in the nation with 304 carries and tied for third with 18 rushing touchdowns, while powering for 1,223 yards.

Army found its featured back in Godspower Nwawuihe, who rushed for 171 yards and two long TDs in the Fenway Bowl win over UConn. Nwawuihe's quarterback background will allow Army to use the sophomore in a variety of formations. Briggs Bartosh stepped away from football due to a neck injury, hurting Army's big-play ability.

The offensive line will always be the team's heartbeat. Army returns four starters up front, including senior center Brady Small, who has started all 39 games since entering the academy.

DEFENSE Army will have a fresh look with eight new starters and a first-year defensive coordinator in longtime assistant Daryl Dixon, who replaced Nate Woody, now at Cincinnati.

Senior nose tackle Kody Harris-Miller enters his third season as a starter and anchors Army's most experienced defensive unit. Junior end Jack Bousum has flashed pro potential, and senior end Dillon Stowers got better and better last season.

Who replaces the production and leadership of captains and graduated inside linebackers Kalib Fortner and Andon Thomas may not be decided until fall camp. Bryson Banks and Elijah Walton should get the first shot. Cornerback Jaydan Mayes, Army's lone returning starter in the secondary, needs to have a big season.

SPECIALISTS Dawson Jones' 15 made field goals were the most by an Army placekicker since 2010, and the junior made his last five field-goal attempts, including a walk-off game-winner against Air Force. Senior punter James Wagenseller, who averaged 43.1 yards last season, is a field-position game-changer.

FINAL ANALYSIS Competing for a conference title isn't out of the question, with the offensive experience that Army is returning. Hellums had 40% of Army's carries last season and needs to share the touches. The team also needs someone to fill the hole left by the departure of Noah Short, who compiled 1,009 yards from scrimmage last year. The Black Knights are younger on defense than in years past, with sophomores Banks and cornerback Julian Porter playing important roles. The inexperience at inside linebacker is also concerning. A home game in Week 2 against South Florida will be a good barometer for whether Army will be a contender.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-4 AMERICAN)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 29	Tarleton State (ot)	L 27-30	Sept. 5	Bryant	1. Phillip Goodrich, LB	★★★
Sept. 6	at Kansas State	W 24-21	Sept. 12	South Florida	2. Maverick Diede, IOL	★★★
Sept. 20	North Texas (ot)	L 38-45	Sept. 26	at Temple	3. Deion Miller, LB	★★★
Sept. 25	at East Carolina	L 6-28	Oct. 3	at Louisiana Tech	4. Kingston Jackson, IOL	★★★
Oct. 4	at UAB	W 31-13	Oct. 10	Tulane	5. Hans Pederson, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 11	Charlotte	W 24-7	Oct. 17	Florida Atlantic	6. Trenton Curliss, TE	★★★
Oct. 18	at Tulane	L 17-24	Oct. 23	at Tulsa	7. Carter Glab, IOL	★★★
Nov. 1	at Air Force	W 20-17	Oct. 31	at Memphis	8. Cayton Kubah-Taylor, S	★★★
Nov. 8	Temple	W 14-13	Nov. 7	Air Force	9. Keoki Becerra, EDGE	★★★
Nov. 22	Tulsa	L 25-26	Nov. 21	East Carolina	10. Omeiza Daniyan, LB	★★★
Nov. 29	at UTSA	W 27-24	Nov. 28	at Rice		
			Dec. 12	vs. Navy #		
				#East Rutherford, NJ		*Per Rivals
TEAM INFORMATION						
Head Coach: Jeff Monken • Record at School: 89-63 (12 years)						
Career Record: 127-79 (16 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Cody Worley						
Defensive Coordinators: Daryl Dixon, Scot Sloan • Location: West Point, N.Y.						
Stadium: Michie Stadium (30,000)						



CALE HELLUMS

SCOUTING THE BLACK KNIGHTS

"It may be wrong to say this, but everyone wants them to win because it's the military. People want them to win because they're doing it for America. [Service academies] are America's team, not the Dallas Cowboys. But for us, that's what's fun about playing them. Our backs are against the wall. And we know when we get a lead against them, they're not gonna bend or break because that's what they train for. ... When those guys leave practice, they go train for war. You always gotta remember that. They play clean, they play the right way. They play physical. ... They're getting who they get. There's no transfer portal, there's nothing for them. They continue to run the same schemes and win 9-10 games a year, and it's like, how?"

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (8)

WR	84	BRADY ANDERSON (JR.)	11	Tobi Olawole (Sr.)
LT	58	HENRY APPLETON (SR.)	78	Xavier Archawski (Jr.)
LG	75	Kyle Kloska (Sr.)	72	Lane Parks (Sr.)
C	51	BRADY SMALL (SR.)	67	Wes Shaw (Jr.)
RG	71	PAOLO GENNARELLI (SR.)	60	Sam Waters (Jr.)
RT	74	TEDDY WILLIAMS (SR.)	56	Tyler Lee (Sr.)
TE	44	PARKER POLOSKEY (SR.)	80	Brian Dyer (Sr.)
QB	3	CALE HELLUMS (SR.)	6	Bryson Luter (So.)
SB	32	Stroman Bridges (So.)	2	Aden Self (Jr.)
SB	27	SAMARI HOWARD (SR.)	1	Zach Mundell (Sr.)
RB	7	Godspower Nwawuihe (So.)	33	Jake Rendina (Sr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	99	JACK BOUSUM (JR.)	94	Javon Smith (Jr.)
DT	52	KODY HARRIS-MILLER (SR.)	91	Sean Donovan (Jr.)
DE	96	Dillon Stowers (Sr.)	97	Cael Newton (Jr.)
ILB	48	Bryson Banks (So.)	19	Jaquavius Moss (So.)
ILB	42	Elijah Walton (Jr.)	29	Kai Woolfolk (So.)
OLB	47	Noah Nixon (Sr.)	49	Christian Yousefzadeh (Sr.)
APACHE	10	Cole Searight (Jr.)	4	CJ Martin (Jr.)
CB	7	JAYDAN MAYES (SR.)	17	Jaxon Hammond (Sr.)
CB	8	Julian Porter (So.)	9	Rob Houston (Jr.)
S	3	Stephen Nnadozie (Sr.)	11	David Thom-Rogers (So.)
S	13	Caleb Williams (Jr.)	32	Christopher Williams (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	95	Dawson Jones (Jr.)	KR	23	Lloyd Benson III (Sr.)
P	47	James Wagenseller (Sr.)	PR	23	Lloyd Benson III (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD



KADIN SCHMITZ

SCOUTING THE 49ERS

"I think [head coach] Tim Albin is one of the best, so if he believes in his team enough to double down, that's scary. But they had one of the worst rosters in college football last year. They really didn't flip it, so you kind of wonder if they believe in it. When Albin was at Ohio, those teams were just so good, and I know their offensive coordinator [Todd Fitch] seems like a great coach. Obviously, it helps that he's been doing it for a while. ... What's scary for us facing them after a year like what they had is that our players could go into that game thinking it's a layup, but s—, all of a sudden ... because that's a good staff."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	14	Adam Hopkins IV (Jr.)	80	Jeremiah Hoffman (Fr.)
WR	1	Jaden Barnes* (Sr.)	89	Derrick Eley (So.)
WR	2	Jaylen Hampton (So.)	4	Tank Boston* (So.)
LT	74	J'Ven Williams* (Jr.)	54	Isaac Sikes-Rasby (Fr.)
LG	67	Dom Silvia (So.)	57	Luke Sandy* (Sr.)
C	65	Nic Cruji* (Sr.)	76	Isaiah Bullerdick (Sr.)
RG	61	Reginhard Pierre-Nau* (Jr.)	66	Omarion Davis (Sr.)
RT	75	KRISTOS FERNANDEZ (SR.)	55	Mathias Nielsen* (Sr.)
TE	17	GUS MCGEE (SR.)	3	Logan Mauldin* (Sr.)
QB	9	Cole Gonzales* (Sr.)	15	Conner Harrell (Sr.)
RB	24	Jariel Cobb (So.)	21	Henry Rutledge (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	7	DJ Burgess (Sr.)	2	JAYLON JOHNSON (SR.)
DT	95	Devin Ancrum* (Fr.)	88	D'Nas White* (So.)
DT	51	JAMARRION SOLOMON (SR.)	15	Ayo Tifase (Sr.)
DE	9	Curtis Simpson (So.)	85	Caleb Irving* (So.)
ILB	19	KADIN SCHMITZ (SR.)	30	Stellan Bowman (So.)
ILB	13	Gavin Willis (Sr.)	36	Parker Startz (So.)
CB	4	Tradarius Smith* (Jr.)	1	Jameel Croft Jr.* (Jr.)
CB	11	DeQuinder Williams II (So.)	12	CJ CLINKSCALES JR. (SR.)
HUSKY	0	Collin Gill (Jr.)	28	Cornell Allen (So.)
S	3	Dy'Lon Womack (So.)	20	Zayden Laing-Taylor* (So.)
S	16	Shamar McIntosh* (So.)	6	Nireek Sharpe* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	84	Aiden Bui (Fr.)	KR	21	Henry Rutledge (Sr.)
P	95	Bronson Long (Sr.)	PR	1	Jaden Barnes* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



CHARLOTTE 49ERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 127 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 14 | 2025 RECORD: 1-11, 0-8 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Charlotte posted its worst offensive output in program history last season, scoring only 14.3 points per game in the first year under head coach Tim Albin and offensive coordinator Todd Fitch. The staff has prioritized beefing up the offensive line and identifying reliable running backs, headlined by the return of Jariel Cobb and Henry Rutledge.

With starting quarterback Conner Harrell missing much of last season and being held out of team periods this spring due to a knee injury, the QB battle has reopened. Transfer Cole Gonzales, formerly at Pitt and FCS Western Carolina, saw plenty of reps in the spring, with the battle for the starting spot coming down to Harrell's health and how fast Gonzales can pick up Fitch's system.

The offense can only be better, and it all begins up front, where transfers J'Ven Williams, Nic Cruji and Reginhard Pierre-Nau are slated to start.

DEFENSE Charlotte's defense returns plenty of familiar faces in the front seven but will see a completely new crop of starters in the secondary. Linebacker Kadin Schmitz is the leading returning tackler with 66, along with two interceptions and two forced fumbles last season. Schmitz and Mike linebacker Gavin Willis lead the defense, with the latter wearing the helmet mic and communicating with defensive coordinator Nate Faanes.

The turn of edges DJ Burgess and Curtis Simpson is huge for Faanes, as the group struggled to rush the passer last season due to injuries. Collin Gill and Dy'Lon Womack are expected to take on significantly bigger roles in the secondary, an area that derailed the defense a season ago.

The talent level on the defense is undoubtedly a step above last season's group, but Albin and Faanes will need a good stroke of injury luck for the unit to reach its full potential.

SPECIALISTS Charlotte has only one kicker on the roster — redshirt freshman Aiden Bui. The expectation is that the team will add at least one more ahead of the season. Bronson Long is expected to serve as the punter, with Pitt transfer Henry Searcy manning the long-snapper position. The return game gets a huge jolt with Rutledge returning for his final year, plus the addition of Jaden Barnes, an Appalachian State transfer.

FINAL ANALYSIS Albin needs a turnaround in Year 2 — which he has been known for in stops at North Dakota State and Ohio. There's some added pressure with new athletic director Kevin White joining the fold following the firing of Mike Hill, who hired Albin.

Albin focused on depth in the portal, but the roster itself doesn't appear much more talented than it did in 2025. If Fitch's offense continues to be stagnant, expect a change there at the conclusion of the season.

2025 RESULTS (1-11, 0-8 AMERICAN)

Aug. 29	Appalachian State	L	11-34
Sept. 6	North Carolina	L	3-20
Sept. 13	Monmouth	W	42-35
Sept. 18	Rice	L	17-28
Oct. 3	at South Florida	L	26-54
Oct. 11	at Army	L	7-24
Oct. 18	Temple	L	14-49
Oct. 24	North Texas	L	20-54
Nov. 8	at East Carolina	L	22-48
Nov. 15	UTSA	L	7-28
Nov. 22	at Georgia	L	3-35
Nov. 29	at Tulane	L	0-27

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	The Citadel
Sept. 12	at Ole Miss
Sept. 19	at App State
Sept. 26	Louisiana
Oct. 3	Memphis
Oct. 10	at North Texas
Oct. 17	at Temple
Oct. 30	Tulane
Nov. 7	at UAB
Nov. 14	East Carolina
Nov. 21	at Tulsa
Nov. 28	Navy

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Jaylen White, QB	★★★
2.	Mason McGill, IOL	★★★
3.	Jerry Wall III, LB	★★★
4.	Max Jansenvanvuren, EDGE	★★★
5.	Mikey Domanik, LB	★★★
6.	Amar Harper, OT	★★★
7.	Colin Bussey, DL	★★★
8.	Cody Taylor, IOL	★★★
9.	La'Trell Sellers, LB	★★★
10.	Josh Hines, S	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Tim Albin • Record at School: 1-11 (1 years) • Career Record: 59-38 (8 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Todd Fitch
Defensive Coordinator: Nate Faanes • Location: Charlotte, N.C. • Stadium: Jerry Richardson Stadium (15,314)



EAST CAROLINA PIRATES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 75 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Two veteran quarterbacks battled all spring, and head coach Blake Harrell likely won't declare a winner until the opener. Texas Tech transfer Mitch Griffis has slightly more experience, but ex-Miami Hurricane Emory Williams, at 6-foot-5, 225, is from QB central casting.

New offensive coordinator Jordan Davis lit up scoreboards at North Texas, and he has a deep wide receiver unit. Returning starter Brock Spalding is back alongside North Texas transfer Landon Sides, who had 88 career catches for 1,092 yards in Davis' offense. FCS Furman import Ja'Keith Hamilton had 40 grabs and five scores while averaging 13.6 yards per reception last year, and there's former Miami (Fla.) slot speedster Ray Ray Joseph, who projects in the return game, too.

Running back TJ Engleman Jr. returns after averaging 5.2 yards per carry last season. Transfers Ashton Gray (North Texas) and Michael Allen (Marshall) should hit the ground running, too. Gray had 152 yards and two scores in the New Mexico Bowl.

All-Conference USA performer Brandon Best, a Kennesaw State transfer, will step right into a depleted line. Southern Miss transfer Hayes Creel is solid, and Ethan Kramer brings 29 starts from FCS Northern Arizona. Experienced returnee Bryce Weaver impressed in the spring.

DEFENSE New defensive coordinator Jordon Hankins must replace a lot of splash plays up front. ECU was fourth with 7.8 tackles for a loss per game in 2025 and 26th nationally in rushing defense (120.3 ypg). Jasiyah Robinson is the only starter back up front. He had five sacks and has fellow veteran leaders Rion Roseborough and Preston Carr alongside him.

Tackling machine DJ Johnson Jr. anchors a linebacking crew with experience and potential. Crews Law, a transfer from Memphis who arrived with Hankins, should help, too. On the backline, nickel Kevon Merrell returns. FIU transfer Ashton Levells-Mitchell and talented Appalachian State addition Zyeir Gamble plug right in to keep the secondary tip-top.

SPECIALISTS Senior Andrew Conrad, the primary placekicker in 2023-24, takes over again this fall. He has hit 36-of-51 career field-goal attempts and tied an NCAA record with five successful field goals of 40-plus yards in a 2023 game. The punting unit depends on the solid foot of Australian Tomas O'Halloran, who averaged 42.1 yards on his 21 boots.

FINAL ANALYSIS The portal swept away lots of star power off another ECU bowl team, but don't be fooled. The Pirates are sneaky good. Guys who have played significant time without necessarily racking up starts are all over the roster. Harrell is 14-5 since taking the helm, and he's the architect of a sack-happy defense and great team culture in Greenville.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*				
Aug. 28	at NC State	L	17-24	Sept. 5	at Alabama	1. Terande Spencer, EDGE	★★★★			
Sept. 6	Campbell	W	56-3	Sept. 12	Appalachian State	2. Chad Fairchild, LB	★★★★			
Sept. 13	at Coastal Carolina	W	38-0	Sept. 19	at Old Dominion	3. Dawson Quarterman, WR	★★★★			
Sept. 20	BYU	L	13-34	Sept. 26	NC Central	4. David Coleman Jr., CB	★★★★			
Sept. 25	Army	W	28-6	Oct. 10	Rice	5. Ja'Vaughn Hargett, OT	★★★★			
Oct. 9	at Tulane	L	19-26	Oct. 15	at UAB	6. Ethan Wilson, DL	★★★★			
Oct. 16	Tulsa	W	41-27	Oct. 22	at Memphis	7. Zyon Ratchford, EDGE	★★★★			
Oct. 31	Temple			Oct. 31	Temple	8. Meliq McGowan, RB	★★★★			
Nov. 1	at Temple	W	45-14	Nov. 6	South Florida	9. Christian Harris, OT	★★★★			
Nov. 8	Charlotte	W	48-22	Nov. 14	at Charlotte	10. Djimon McLendon, S	★★★★			
Nov. 15	Memphis	W	31-27	Nov. 21	at Army					
Nov. 22	at UTSA	L	24-58	Nov. 28	Florida Atlantic					
Nov. 29	at Florida Atlantic	W	42-3							
Dec. 27	vs. Pitt #	W	23-17							
#Military Bowl				*Per Rivals						
TEAM INFORMATION										
Head Coach: Blake Harrell • Record at School: 14-5 (1+ years)										
Career Record: 14-5 (1+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jordan Davis										
Defensive Coordinators: Jordon Hankins, Roy Tesh • Location: Greenville, N.C.										
Stadium: Dowdy-Ficklen Stadium (51,000)										



BROCK SPALDING

SCOUTING THE PIRATES

"That's always a tough game for us. They're very comfortable and very good at what they do. They definitely create some issues defensively the way that they aggressively fit the run and with how aggressive they are on the back end. ... Whatever [head coach Blake Harrell] is doing behind closed doors, they're believing in it. Over the years, that program has been very well-funded. I think it's one of those situations where they have a history of success, and that helps them. They're a recognizable brand. For them, the next step is to win a conference championship and really take that to another level. I hope that they don't figure that out this year."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	25	Landon Sides* (Sr.)	21	Jeremiah Melvin* (So.)
WR	10	BROCK SPALDING (SR.)	11	Ray Ray Joseph* (Jr.)
WR	80	Ty Johnson (So.)	19	Ja'Keith Hamilton* (Jr.)
LT	71	Bryce Weaver (Jr.)	66	Marleo Neolien (Jr.)
LG	73	Karson Jones (Jr.)	69	Kendall Walton (Fr.)
C	58	Brandon Best* (Sr.)	73	Carson Jones (Jr.)
RG	55	Ethan Kramer* (Sr.)	68	Tre Hardison (Sr.)
RT	75	Hayes Creel* (Sr.)	72	Christian Harris* (Jr.)
TE	88	Ismael Smith Flores (Jr.)	89	Kanen Hamlett* (Sr.)
QB	12	Mitch Griffis* (Sr.)	11	Emory Williams* (Jr.)
RB	23	Ashton Gray* (So.)	20	TJ Engleman Jr. (So.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	8	JASIYAH ROBINSON (SR.)	35	Kieran Davis (Jr.)
NT	44	Preston Carr (Sr.)	94	Javon Williams (So.)
DT	93	Rion Roseborough (Jr.)	98	Torin Brazell (So.)
SLB	42	Julien Davis (Jr.)	40	Kendrick Dujour (Sr.)
MLB	11	DJ JOHNSON JR. (JR.)	47	Cade Law* (Sr.)
WLB	45	Crews Law* (So.)	1	Jackson Barker (Sr.)
CB	14	Ashton Levells-Mitchell* (Sr.)	15	Jaylen Bowden* (Sr.)
CB	31	Derrion Horsley (Fr.)	17	Rae'mon Mosby* (So.)
NB	4	Kevon Merrell (Jr.)	25	Christian Peterson* (Jr.)
S	28	Zyeir Gamble* (Jr.)	13	Ayden Duncanson (Jr.)
S	6	DeMarius Hines (So.)	12	Myles Pollard* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	95	Andrew Conrad (Sr.)	KR	11	Ray Ray Joseph* (Jr.)
P	48	Tomas O'Halloran (So.)	PR	0	Kyler Pearson (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • 2026 TRANSFER



CADEN VELTKAMP

SCOUTING THE OWLS

"I think [head coach] Zach Kittley will get it going. He runs a style of offense that can find some diamonds in the rough and be really successful with him because he's unique in a very different way from the Armys and Navys of the world. Some of the frustration at a place like that is that there are just so many good teams in the state of Florida. You're just competing with so many other guys to be able to get those types of kids. ... It sounds like the biggest thing with them is that their money just doesn't match up with the rest of the league. Kittley sounds like an awesome dude, and I'm definitely rooting for them. It just seems like it's tough the further into NIL and rev-share that we get."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	2	Kelby Valsin* (Jr.)	0	Branden Hoch (So.)
WR	9	DOMINIQUE HENRY (SR.)	6	RJ Garcia II* (Sr.)
WR	8	EASTON MESSER (SR.)	4	Antojuan Woody* (Jr.)
LT	57	JA'KAVION NONAR (SR.)	73	Kortez Winslow* (So.)
LG	60	Aqil Meredith-Smith* (So.)	72	Ovie Dubre (Jr.)
C	65	Braden Cunningham (So.)	52	Logan Husband (So.)
RG	62	VINCENT FIACABLE (SR.)	75	Mauricio Hinds (So.)
RT	74	Ben Galloway* (Jr.)	71	Landon Rapkiewicz (So.)
TE	19	AJ Johnson* (Sr.)	11	Brooks Johnson* (Sr.)
QB	10	CADEN VELTKAMP (SR.)	18	Drew Devillier* (So.)
RB	28	Kaden Shields-Dutton (Jr.)	22	Brady Tillman III* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (6)

DE	12	Jay Crable* (Jr.)	5	DESHAUN BATISTE (SR.)
DT	1	CJ DOGGETTE JR. (SR.)	94	Corey Clark* (Sr.)
DT	98	Blake Burris* (Sr.)	2	Wilky Denaud (Jr.)
DE	9	Jonathan Bax* (Sr.)	11	GAVENCH MARCELIN (JR.)
LB	18	Joseph Sipp Jr.* (Sr.)	7	Khmari Johnson (Jr.)
LB	6	LEON HART JR. (JR.)	43	Hector Chavez (So.)
CB	4	DAMARIUS MCGHEE (SR.)	26	Amar Reynolds* (So.)
CB	23	JK Johnson* (Sr.)	27	Travis Jackson (Fr.)
NB	3	Derrick Rogers (Jr.)	8	CHRIS TOOLEY III (JR.)
S	0	Damon Allen (So.)	19	Tyson Rooks* (Sr.)
S	22	Jayden Sweeney (Sr.)	24	Ahlston Ware (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	41	Collin Rogers* (Sr.)	KR	2	Kelby Valsin* (Jr.)
P	91	Reed Chandley* (Jr.)	PR	8	Easton Messer (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



FLORIDA ATLANTIC OWLS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 96 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 9 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 3-5 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Importing the quarterback-wide receiver tandem of Caden Veltkamp and Easton Messer from WKU bore fruit in head coach Zach Kittley's first season in Boca Raton. FAU flirted with a 30 points per game average and bested North Texas in passing yards per game. But the week-to-week production was inconsistent. Veltkamp threw for a program-record 494 yards in a shootout loss to UConn. One week later, FAU managed just a field goal in a blowout loss to East Carolina. Turnovers were a persistent issue, as Veltkamp paced the FBS in interceptions (17), and the Owls led all teams in giveaways (29).

Familiarity is one thing in FAU's favor — five starters are back on offense, including two on the line. Year 2 in Kittley's offense could yield further fireworks. And perhaps the pivot to Kaden Shields-Dutton in the backfield will produce a more reliable run game to diversify one of the most pass-happy offenses in college football.

DEFENSE For better or for worse, the Owls bring back more than half of their starters from the group that allowed the most points per game (36.3) in program history. FAU was one of 10 teams that gave up more than 200 yards per game both rushing and passing.

Top tackler Leon Hart Jr. and leading sack-getter CJ Doggette Jr. are decorated returnees. Linebacker Joseph Sipp Jr. (Kansas) and defensive tackle Blake Burris (SMU) arrived via the portal to bolster a group that was gashed on the ground. Though the offense put the defense in a bad position with turnovers, the defense was almost as bad at forcing takeaways. FAU's eight turnovers forced were the fifth fewest in the FBS.

The secondary underwent a considerable overhaul, but some of the new blood could help stop the bleeding over the top. Division II All-American and national champion Ahlston Ware transferred from Ferris State to provide some playmaking help at safety.

SPECIALISTS Newcomers at punter and kicker could provide an upgrade at both positions. Reed Chandley comes to FAU from Georgia State, where he led the Sun Belt in punting average (45.8). And placekicker Collin Rogers transferred in from SMU, where he's the all-time leading scorer. Wide receiver Easton Messer will continue returning punts after leading the conference in return average (20.8). Fellow wideout Kelby Valsin could take over kickoff return duties.

FINAL ANALYSIS It will take considerable improvement on defense for FAU to even dream of its first bowl bid since 2020. If that materializes, and Veltkamp cuts down on the turnovers, there's a path to improvement — and maybe even six wins — for the Owls despite a difficult early schedule.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 3-5 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at Maryland	L	7-39	Sept. 5	at Florida	1. Aedyn Buchanan, OT	★★★★
Sept. 6	Florida A&M	W	56-14	Sept. 12	Navy	2. Travis Jackson, CB	★★★
Sept. 13	at FIU	L	28-38	Sept. 19	FIU	3. Nicsaint Joseph Jr., WR	★★★
Sept. 27	Memphis	L	26-55	Sept. 26	at ULM	4. Sean Williams, CB	★★★
Oct. 4	at Rice	W	27-21	Oct. 3	Texas Southern	5. Jeremiah Daoud, QB	★★★★
Oct. 11	UAB	W	53-33	Oct. 17	at Army	6. Elijah West, WR	★★★★
Oct. 18	at South Florida	L	13-48	Oct. 24	Rice	7. Antojuan Woody, WR	★★★★
Oct. 25	at Navy	L	32-42	Oct. 29	at North Texas	8. Alejandro Schmitt, OT	★★★★
Nov. 8	Tulsa	W	40-21	Nov. 5	UTSA	9. Owen Pollock, TE	★★★
Nov. 15	at Tulane	L	24-35	Nov. 14	at Tulsa	10. Justin Weatherall, WR	★★★★
Nov. 22	UConn	L	45-48	Nov. 21	South Florida		
Nov. 29	East Carolina	L	3-42	Nov. 28	at East Carolina		

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Zach Kittley • Record at School: 4-8 (1 year) • Career Record: 4-8 (1 year) • Offensive Coordinator: Zach Kittley
Defensive Coordinator: Brett Dewhurst • Location: Boca Raton, Fla. • Stadium: Flagler Credit Union Stadium (30,000)



MEMPHIS TIGERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 66 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 8-5, 4-4 AMERICAN

OFFENSE New offensive coordinator Kevin Decker will bring a fast, spread-style attack that was successful at Old Dominion, although his quarterbacks are unproven at the FBS level. Marcus Stokes, a finalist for the Div. II Harlon Hill Trophy in 2025 while at West Florida, is expected to land the starting job but will get competition from South Carolina transfer Air Noland, who appeared in only two games for the Gamecocks in 2025.

Transfer running back Jaylin Carter (Southern Miss) followed first-year head coach Charlie Huff from Hattiesburg to Memphis. Carter, Manny Covey (Cincinnati) and Dallan Hayden (Colorado) should get the bulk of the carries. Hayden, a Memphis native, is a powerful back who had 70 carries for 326 yards last season.

Receivers will line up wider in Decker's scheme. Speedy Alante Brown, a Michigan State transfer granted a seventh year of eligibility, is a big-play candidate, as is Southern Miss transfer Tychaun Chapman.

DEFENSE An abundance of Southern Miss transfers will pace the defense. Linebacker Mike Montgomery and safety Ian Foster, both arriving from Southern Miss, will be the leaders of the unit under the direction of coordinator Lance Guidry, who will implement a 4-2-5 scheme. Guidry spent last season as an analyst at LSU. Foster, expected to play nickel corner in the 4-2-5, is a punishing tackler who can effectively blitz off the edge as well as play smothering man-to-man defense.

J'Mond Tapp, another ex-Southern Miss standout, will anchor the defensive line. Guidry needs to find complements for Montgomery; the rest of the linebackers have amassed only 23 career tackles.

SPECIALISTS Foster, Brown and Covey are experienced return specialists. As a freshman at Marshall in 2024, Foster led the nation in kickoff returns of 50 or more yards (three) and 40 or more yards (five). Brown returned four kicks for a 53.5-yard average in 2025. Covey averaged nearly 10 yards per punt return last season at Cincinnati. Harrison Tuck is a former Australian Rules Football player who spent the past three seasons punting at FCS Alabama State. He averaged 41.8 yards per punt in 2025.

FINAL ANALYSIS There will be many new pieces for the Tigers, including a new head coach and coordinators, new quarterbacks and a roster composed mostly of transfers. It's a challenge for Huff, a Nick Saban disciple with a successful track record. He's brought with him a group of talented players from Southern Miss. If Stokes can quickly adapt to Decker's offense and the speed of FBS defenses, the Tigers' defense should hold its own behind Foster and Montgomery. Huff's goal is to lead the Tigers back to the American Championship Game for the first time since 2019.

2025 RESULTS (8-5, 4-4 AMERICAN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Chattanooga W 45-10	Aug. 29 at UNLV	1. Elijah Fernandez, LB ★★★★★
Sept. 6 at Georgia State W 38-16	Sept. 5 Arkansas State	2. Eric Perry, RB ★★★
Sept. 13 at Troy W 28-7	Sept. 12 at Boise State	3. Jaylin Taylor, WR ★★★
Sept. 20 Arkansas W 32-31	Sept. 19 Tennessee-Martin	4. JT Barlow, S ★★★
Sept. 27 at Florida Atlantic W 55-26	Oct. 3 at Charlotte	5. Zechariah Jenkins, WR ★★★
Oct. 4 Tulsa W 45-7	Oct. 10 UAB	6. Johnny Moody, CB ★★★
Oct. 18 at UAB L 24-31	Oct. 16 at Tulane	7. Richard Thigpen, OT ★★★
Oct. 25 South Florida W 34-31	Oct. 22 East Carolina	8. Tim Sims, S ★★★
Oct. 31 at Rice W 38-14	Oct. 31 Army	9. Jordan Thompson, RB ★★★
Nov. 7 Tulane L 32-38	Nov. 12 at South Florida	10. Kadan Spratling, LB ★★★
Nov. 15 at East Carolina L 27-31	Nov. 21 at Navy	
Nov. 27 Navy L 17-28	Nov. 28 Temple	*Per Rivals
Dec. 19 vs. NC State # L 7-31		
#Gasparilla Bowl		
	TEAM INFORMATION	
	Head Coach: Charles Huff • Record at School: First Season	
	Career Record: 39-25 (5 seasons) • Offensive Coordinators: Kevin Decker,	
	David Weeks • Defensive Coordinator: Lance Guidry • Location: Memphis,	
	Tenn. • Stadium: Simmons Bank Liberty Stadium (50,000)	



BRADY KLUSE

SCOUTING THE TIGERS

"[New Memphis head coach] Charles Huff is a good coach. He's a guy that has done it the hard way, having not been a coordinator, but has just found a way to be successful. ... That's a good mold for him at Memphis. He's gonna have those kids grinding. You see the soundbites about him having no music [at practice] — I like it. He sticks to who he is, and for all we know, they're playing music at practice right now. Who knows? But whatever his ammunition to get guys going is, it works because he's been successful as a head coach, and there's a reason why he's gotten those opportunities. I really think he'll do a good job there."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (I)

WR	1	Tychaun Chapman* (Sr.)	8	Bryce Dorsey (So.)
WR	13	Jemyri Davis* (Jr.)	4	Terrell Timmons Jr.* (Sr.)
WR	17	Alante Brown* (Sr.)	12	Brady Kluse (Jr.)
LT	78	Riley McGehee* (Jr.)	71	Xavier Allen* (Sr.)
LG	70	PARKER MITCHELL (SR.)	75	Skyler Grant* (Sr.)
C	50	Koby Keenum* (Jr.)	73	Phillip Gray* (Sr.)
RG	65	Maarten Woudsma* (Sr.)	77	Brian Grant* (Sr.)
RT	59	Aaron Karas* (Sr.)	68	Jonathan Young (Sr.)
TE	0	Hunter Tipton* (Sr.)	18	TJ Johnson* (Jr.)
QB	2	Marcus Stokes* (Jr.)	3	Air Noland* (So.)
RB	6	Jaylin Carter* (So.)	28	Manny Covey* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (O)

DE	14	J'Mond Tapp* (Sr.)	93	Jabari Ishmael* (Sr.)
NG	11	Jaden McKinney* (Sr.)	94	J'Mari Monette* (Sr.)
DT	90	Taylor Burton (Sr.)	18	Xavier Miles* (Jr.)
DE	15	Elijah Kinsler* (So.)	4	Joseph Head Jr.* (Jr.)
MLB	23	Jayden Parrish* (So.)	41	Tylon Nash (Sr.)
WLB	9	Mike Montgomery* (Sr.)	43	Wolf Walker (Fr.)
CB	1	Ellis Ellis Jr.* (Sr.)	8	Anthony Richard Jr.* (Sr.)
CB	2	Chauncey Logan Jr. (Sr.)	7	Darius Malcolm Jr.* (So.)
NB	0	Ian Foster* (Jr.)	12	Beni Mwamba (Jr.)*
S	5	Ahmere Foster* (Sr.)	27	Jordan Bell (So.)
S	3	Dylan Smith* (Jr.)	6	Dylan King* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	80	Philippe Laforge* (So.)	KR	0	Ian Foster* (Jr.)
P	30	Harrison Tuck* (Sr.)	PR	28	Manny Covey* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



BRAXTON WOODSON

SCOUTING THE MIDSHIPMEN

"They're not dealing with the NIL and transfer portal world quite as much as everybody else is. I think that there are pros and cons to that. [Navy] certainly leans in on the pros. They know who they are and who is going to be back for them. Offensively, they're obviously really hard to prep for. ... Even looking at them from a defensive perspective, they're pretty multiple with what they do, given the type of retention that they can have and with the type of student that can attend such a prestigious institution. That's the prep difficulty and why they've been so good. I think that they should be really good again."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	89	Luke Hutchison (Sr.)	86	Josh Guerin (Sr.)
LT	73	SEAN CROWLEY (JR.)	65	Connor Heater (Jr.)
LG	70	Jake Polito (Jr.)	66	Will Hampton (So.)
C	69	CAM NICHOLS (SR.)	63	Toran Smith (Jr.)
RG	79	HOKE SMITH II (SR.)	52	Matt Tomaszewski (So.)
RT	77	MALCOLM JOHNSON (SO.)	60	Zarian Simms (Sr.)
TE	85	Jake Norris (Sr.)	36	Jordan Collins (So.)
QB	5	Braxton Woodson (Sr.)	8	Jackson Gutierrez (Jr.)
SB	23	Charles Robinson (Jr.)	2	Robert Jones III (Jr.)
SB	25	Isaiah Bryant (Sr.)	26	Michael Barrow (Jr.)
RB	40	Vic Listorti (Sr.)	35	Quinton Ezzard (Jr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	65	Aiden Lyczek (Jr.)	70	Ikenna Ozurumba (Sr.)
NG	94	Xavier Arrington (Jr.)	99	Chris Herock (Jr.)
DT	95	GRIFFEN WILLIS (SR.)	97	Matt Reyes (Sr.)
OLB	18	Will Miller (So.)	14	Trent Gillis (So.)
ILB	58	COLEMAN CAULEY (SR.)	53	Marcus Bleazard (Sr.)
ILB	56	MARCANTHONY PARKER (JR.)	52	Nolan McCamy (Sr.)
OLB	45	Christian Johnson (So.)	39	Job Grant (Sr.)
CB	10	Nick Bell (Jr.)	28	Bryce Allen (Sr.)
CB	3	Irabonaise Oniha (Sr.)	13	Cam Robinson (So.)
SS	16	GIUSEPPE SESSI (SR.)	5	Matthew Seliga (Sr.)
FS	6	PHILLIP HAMILTON (JR.)	8	Aaron Rose (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	95	Justin Welch (So.)	KR	25	Isaiah Bryant (Sr.)
P	15	Jacob Carlson (Jr.)	PR	23	Charles Robinson (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD



NAVY MIDSHIPMEN

NATIONAL FORECAST: 60 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 11-2, 7-1 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Navy bid farewell to its big three of quarterback Blake Horvath, running back Alex Tecza and slotback Eli Heidenreich, who accounted for 68% of the yards from scrimmage last season. Braxton Woodson takes over at quarterback after displaying dynamic running ability. The 6-foot-3 senior possesses sprinter's speed and has broken numerous long runs while seeing time at quarterback, slotback and wide receiver.

Senior running back Vic Listorti missed most of last season with a lingering hamstring injury and remains a question mark. Junior slotback Charles Robinson emerged as a playmaker during spring practice, earning the Admiral Mack Award as Navy's most improved player. Senior wide receiver Luke Hutchison, who missed seven games with a shoulder injury last season, is the team's fastest offensive player and could become a downfield threat. In the third season of his hybrid Wing-T offense, coordinator Drew Cronin says it's time for the split ends and tight ends to become impact performers in the passing game.

Senior guard Hoke Smith II is one of four returning starters along an offensive line that paved the way for Navy to lead the nation in rushing offense (285.6 yards per game).

DEFENSE The Midshipmen must replace some losses up front, including first-team All-America nose guard Landon Robinson, making the pass rush a genuine concern.

Navy does return two highly productive inside linebackers in MarcAnthony Parker and Coleman Cauley, who combined for 176 tackles last season. Safety Giuseppe Sessi was second on the squad with 81 tackles and called the defensive signals.

Pass defense was a problem for most of last season but improved dramatically down the stretch after Phillip Hamilton moved to safety. Starting corners Nick Bell and Irabonaise Oniha bring experience.

SPECIALISTS Punter Jacob Carlson averaged 44.5 yards in his first season as the starter. While Justin Welch will enter August training camp atop the depth chart at placekicker, the position battle figures to continue right up to the opener. Slotback Isaiah Bryant has been a productive kickoff returner and may now be asked to handle punts as well.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Middies are relying on several unproven players to fill important roles, especially on offense. But Navy takes great pride in being a developmental program, and it has become commonplace for previously unknown players to emerge. Fourth-year head coach Brian Newberry is confident that he has built a program that can reload.

2025 RESULTS (11-2, 7-1 AMERICAN)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 VMI W 52-7	Sept. 5 Towson	1. Alexander Brewer, IOL ★★★
Sept. 6 UAB W 38-24	Sept. 12 at Florida Atlantic	2. Kaden Olson, S ★★★
Sept. 13 at Tulsa W 42-23	Sept. 25 at UAB	3. Kaden Glover, TE ★★★
Sept. 27 Rice W 21-13	Oct. 3 at Air Force	4. Adrian Symalla, RB ★★★
Oct. 4 Air Force W 34-31	Oct. 10 Tulsa	5. Ian Campbell, EDGE ★★★
Oct. 11 at Temple W 32-31	Oct. 17 at UTSA	6. Clinton Lee, WR ★★★
Oct. 25 Florida Atlantic W 42-32	Oct. 24 North Texas	7. Deuce Jefferson, QB ★★★
Nov. 1 at North Texas L 17-31	Oct. 31 vs. Notre Dame #	8. Darren Jackson, LB ★★★
Nov. 8 at Notre Dame L 10-49	Nov. 7 Temple	9. Peter Bonnet, OT ★★★
Nov. 15 South Florida W 41-38	Nov. 21 Memphis	10. Dakarion Jamison, S ★★★
Nov. 27 at Memphis W 28-17	Nov. 28 at Charlotte	
Dec. 13 vs. Army # W 17-16	Dec. 12 vs. Army %	
Jan. 2 vs. Cincinnati % W 35-13		
#Baltimore %Liberty Bowl		#Forsyth, MA %East Rutherford, NJ

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Brian Newberry • Record at School: 26-12 (3 years) • Career Record: 26-12 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Drew Cronin
Defensive Coordinators: Eric Lewis, Ricky Brown • Location: Annapolis, Md. • Stadium: Navy-Marine Corps Memorial Stadium (34,000)



NORTH TEXAS MEAN GREEN

NATIONAL FORECAST: 109 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 11 | 2025 RECORD: 12-2, 7-1 AMERICAN

OFFENSE North Texas boasted one of the top offenses in college football a year ago, averaging an FBS-leading 512.4 yards and 45.1 points per game en route to a 12-win season and American Conference Championship Game appearance. Head coach Eric Morris, the mastermind behind it all, is now at Oklahoma State. So are quarterback Drew Mestemaker, wide receiver Wyatt Young and running back Caleb Hawkins.

Former Troy and West Virginia head coach Neal Brown takes over the program after serving on the Texas staff last season and inherits an offense with no returning starters.

Quarterback Chris Jimerson Jr. appeared in four games as a true freshman. Transfers will be critically important at the skill positions. Wide receiver TJ Chukwurah was a Division II All-American at Black Hills State, and ex-West Virginia running back Jahiem White was a Freshman All-American under Brown for the Mountaineers in 2023.

Much of the offensive line that paved the way for the most rushing TDs in the country is gone, but Georgia Southern transfer Chandler Strong has 30 career starts and will fill one vacancy.

DEFENSE UNT struggled at times on defense, allowing 381.9 yards and 26.5 points per game. The Mean Green ranked 130th nationally in run defense, giving up 215.7 rushing yards per game. Conversely, pass defense was a strong point, limiting teams to just 166.2 yards (eighth in the FBS). First-year defensive coordinator Matt Powledge, who held that position at Baylor the past three years, will have his work cut out for him.

Terrell Washington has the most experience among returning defensive linemen. The additions of transfers Aaron Alexander (Arkansas State) and Zakye Baker (SMU) should bolster the linebacking corps.

Twin defensive backs Caden and Cameren Jenkins both followed Powledge from Baylor to Denton and should fill starting roles.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Kali Nguma made 92.3% of his field-goal attempts last season before transferring to Colorado State. Former Appalachian State kicker Dominic De Freitas (20-of-25 FGs, 33-of-33 PATs) will replace him. The Mean Green ranked fifth in kick returns and 14th in punt returns in the American last season but must find replacements after losing Simeon Evans and Miles Coleman.

FINAL ANALYSIS Running the ball has been a staple of Brown-coached offenses, so expect the Mean Green to lean heavily on the run game. Several new faces on defense bring a lot of questions with them, too, but change could be good after the unit's inconsistent showing the past two years.

2025 RESULTS (12-2, 7-1 AMERICAN)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Lamar	W 51-0	Sept. 5	at Indiana	1. Caden Valtaire, OT	★★★
Sept. 6	at W. Michigan (ot)	W 33-30	Sept. 12	UNLV	2. Lathon Latiolais, WR	★★★
Sept. 13	Washington State	W 59-10	Sept. 19	at Texas State	3. Cason Applewhite, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 20	at Army (ot)	W 45-38	Sept. 26	Houston Christian	4. Jerious Singletary, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 27	South Alabama	W 36-22	Oct. 1	at Tulsa	5. KC Ekwu, OT	★★★
Oct. 10	South Florida	L 36-63	Oct. 10	Charlotte	6. Adarion Nettles, RB	★★★
Oct. 18	UTSA	W 55-17	Oct. 24	at Navy	7. Grady Holmes, DL	★★★
Oct. 24	at Charlotte	W 54-20	Oct. 29	Florida Atlantic	8. Courage Osawe Jr., DL	★★★
Nov. 1	Navy	W 31-17	Nov. 7	Rice	9. Tyson Wilson, S	★★★
Nov. 15	at UAB	W 53-24	Nov. 14	at UTSA	10. Ziondre Williams, QB	★★★
Nov. 22	at Rice	W 56-24	Nov. 21	at Tulane		
Nov. 28	Temple	W 52-25	Nov. 28	UAB		*Per Rivals
Dec. 5	at Tulane #	L 21-34	TEAM INFORMATION			
Dec. 27	vs. San Diego State %	W 49-47	Head Coach: Neal Brown • Record at School: First Season			
#AAC Championship %New Mexico Bowl			Career Record: 72-51 (10 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Neal Brown			
			Defensive Coordinators: Matt Powledge, Bradley Dale Peveto			
			Location: Denton, Texas • Stadium: DATCU Stadium (30,100)			



DALTON CARNES

SCOUTING THE MEAN GREEN

"You see the similarities in the coaching trees and what they believe philosophically will be pretty similar. I think you should see that thing continue to go. It'll be interesting to see what they do at quarterback, but it should be more of the same under [new head coach] Neal Brown. It should have the same feel when you watch them as what Eric Morris did. ... We've been getting stuck recruiting against them a lot lately. Obviously, I know that it's going to be really tough to sustain what they did last year. But with all the talent that they have to recruit in that area, I would think that they'll be able to stay in that 8-10-win conversation every year."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (O)

WR	3	TJ Chukwurah* (Sr.)	8	Shandon King (Jr.)
WR	16	James Tyre* (Jr.)	19	Grayson O'Bara (Sr.)
WR	11	Dalton Carnes (Sr.)	80	Baron Tipton (So.)
LT	79	Jordan Reasonover (Fr.)		KC Ekwu (Fr.)
LG	72	Neto Umeozulu* (Sr.)	53	Dylan Shaw (So.)
C	57	Chandler Strong* (Sr.)	61	Drew Cunningham* (So.)
RG	54	Henry Fenuku* (Fr.)	68	Keon Johnson (Jr.)
RT	71	Johnny Williams IV* (Jr.)	70	Brody Hamilton (Fr.)
TE	7	Max Reese* (Sr.)	88	Victor Aderungboye (So.)
QB	12	Chris Jimerson Jr. (Fr.)	16	Tom von Grote (Fr.)
RB	1	Jahiem White* (Jr.)	5	Jayden Becks (Jr.)

DEFENSE (D)

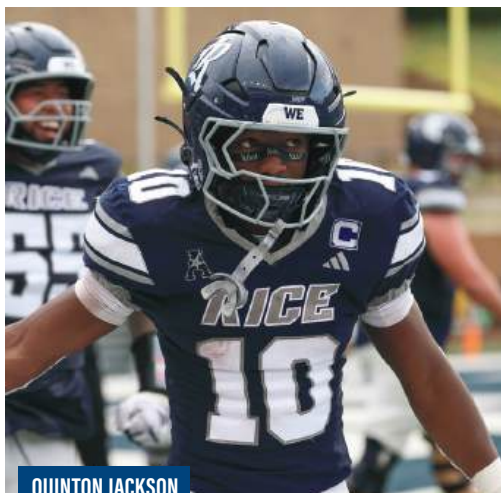
DE	91	Davion Rhodes* (Sr.)	6	Udoka Ezeani* (Sr.)
NT	95	Rudy Vargas Jr. (Sr.)	99	Avion Carter (Jr.)
DT	93	Terrell Washington (Jr.)	15	Justin Benton* (Jr.)
DE	10	David Onuoha* (Sr.)	97	Demetrie Morgan (Sr.)
LB	3	Zakye Barker* (Sr.)	17	Cedric Roberts* (Jr.)
LB	7	Aaron Alexander* (Sr.)	26	S'Maje Burrell (Jr.)
LB	30	Chantz Johnson* (Jr.)	34	Brenden Reese (So.)
CB	4	CJ Coombes* (Jr.)	16	BJ Allen Jr. (Sr.)
CB	8	Caden Jenkins* (Sr.)	1	Keshawn Davila* (Sr.)
S	9	Cameren Jenkins* (Jr.)	22	Julian Knox (So.)
S	21	Jason Cross Jr.* (So.)	29	Kamdon McFarland (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	90	Dominic De Freitas* (So.)	KR	16	James Tyre* (Jr.)
P	37	Will Hutchison (Jr.)	PR	16	James Tyre* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

JOHN E. MOORE III/GETTY IMAGES



QUINTON JACKSON

SCOUTING THE OWLS

"Schematically, they do good stuff on offense that challenges people just because it's so hard to see with that triple option. What's interesting about this league is there are three teams who are like that, but it's hard to prepare for, and that'll start to give people fits. ... [Head coach] Scott Abell is gonna do a great job. That's how you've gotta play over there with a specific brand of football to be able to attack a specific type of player. ... When you have the ball against them, it feels like all the pressure is on you because if you don't score or pick up a couple first downs, you aren't getting the ball back for five, six, seven minutes. Yeah, Abell is gonna do a really good job."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	81	Braylen Walker (Sr.)	88	Keenan Arcega-Whiteside (Fr.)
WR	0	Payton Matthews (So.)	7	Barry Jackson Jr.* (Jr.)
WR	19	Jordan Clark (Fr.)	6	Ben Grice* (So.)
LT	58	Peyton Farmer (Jr.)	67	Luke Needham (Jr.)
LG	50	PATRICK VALENT (JR.)	78	Erben Birkhoff (Fr.)
C	56	Nate Bledsoe (Jr.)	62	Cullen Witt (So.)
RG	71	Cole Principe (So.)	77	Ian Bothwell (Fr.)
RT	73	Justin Michaelis (Sr.)	53	LUKE MILLER (SO.)
TE	86	James Falk (Jr.)	91	DD Oliver (Fr.)
QB	11	Jacurri Brown* (Sr.)	4	Gael Ochoa* (So.)
RB	10	QUINTON JACKSON (SR.)	28	D'Andre Hardeman Jr. (So.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	8	JOSEPH MUTOMBO (JR.)	94	Braden Bays (Fr.)
DT	57	Aquantis Clemmons (Jr.)	15	Matthew Aribisala (Sr.)
DT	96	DILLAN BOTTS (SR.)	11	Christopher Clark-Jolivet (Jr.)
RUSH	16	Chibby Nwajaku (Sr.)	42	DeReyon Jenkins (Fr.)
LB	14	Beau Barton (Jr.)	34	Kaleb Blanton (So.)
LB	44	Cooper King (Jr.)	99	Jesus Machado Jr.* (Sr.)
VIPER	2	Jo Chavez (Jr.)	7	AJ Brown* (Sr.)
CB	4	Tariq Watson* (Sr.)	10	Kyren Condoll* (So.)
CB	5	Jerrick Harper (Sr.)	12	Jamir Benjamin* (So.)
S	18	Ahran Ogbor (So.)	20	Bailey Fletcher (So.)
S	0	Daveon Hook (Sr.)	23	Michael Amey III (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	28	Enock Gota (Sr.)	KR	10	Quinton Jackson (Sr.)
P	29	Charlie Durkin* (Sr.)	PR	10	Quinton Jackson (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN **BOLD** • *2026 TRANSFER



RICE OWLS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 120 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 12 | 2025 RECORD: 5-8, 2-6 AMERICAN

OFFENSE The Owls became run-heavy and predictable at times last season. Head coach Scott Abell, who is entering his second season at the helm after a 5-8 debut, implemented his own version of the option offense last season, and the Owls had success running it, but there will be a new quarterback under center for a second straight season. After Chase Jenkins left via the transfer portal, Abell brought in transfers Jacurri Brown, who had stops at Miami (Fla.) and UCF, and Gael Ochoa (UNLV) to run the offense.

Whoever is under center will be tasked with improving a unit that averaged 19.1 points per game last season and had most of its success on the ground, averaging nearly 205 rushing yards per game. Leading rusher Quentin Jackson returns, but the Owls lost most of their skill position players to graduation or the portal.

DEFENSE The Owls' defense lost most of its starters and the top seven tacklers to graduation and the transfer portal, so it might take a few games for Rice to find its groove on that side of the ball.

Viper Jo Chavez and defensive end Joseph Mutombo will be among the returning players who will lead a unit that surrendered nearly 33 points and 404 yards per contest. The Owls need more takeaways after forcing only seven last season, and they also must do a better job of stopping teams in the red zone after opposing offenses scored on all 41 red-zone trips last season, including 30 touchdowns.

SPECIALISTS Enock Gota returns as the primary placekicker. Gota was 10-of-13 on field goals last season, but he has yet to hit from beyond 50 yards. Gota is solid on kickoffs with 37 touchbacks each of the past two seasons. Punter Charlie Durkin comes to Rice after a good season with Kent State, where he averaged 41.4 yards per punt, including six over 50 yards, and placed 14 inside the 20-yard line.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Owls were improved in Abell's first season, appearing in a bowl game despite their losing record thanks to having the highest Academic Progress Rate among five-win teams. Rice will have a chance to compete for a bowl game again this season, but the Owls were forced to retool through the portal after losing more than 50 players to graduation and transfers.

The Owls have to find a way to score after surpassing the 20-point mark in only five games last season and in only two of their eight losses. The defense was on the field too much due to the inability of the offense to sustain drives, so the success of the Owls this season could come down simply to moving the sticks.

2025 RESULTS (5-8, 2-6 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at Louisiana	W	14-12	Sept. 5	Houston Christian	1. Ayden Wilhelm, QB	★★★
Sept. 6	Houston	L	9-35	Sept. 12	at Notre Dame	2. Marcus Page Jr., OT	★★★
Sept. 13	Prairie View	W	38-17	Sept. 19	Western Michigan	3. Chris Knauls, DL	★★★
Sept. 18	at Charlotte	W	28-17	Sept. 26	at Fresno State	4. Seth Clarke, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 27	at Navy	L	13-21	Oct. 3	UTSA	5. Jayden Cupitt, LB	★★★
Oct. 4	Florida Atlantic	L	21-27	Oct. 10	at East Carolina	6. Justin Powell, RB	★★★
Oct. 11	at UTSA	L	13-61	Oct. 17	Tulsa	7. Brock Reddic, DL	★★★
Oct. 25	UConn (ot)	W	37-34	Oct. 24	at Florida Atlantic	8. Leyonte Chandler, OT	★★★
Oct. 31	Memphis	L	14-38	Nov. 7	at North Texas	9. Sawyer Rice, ATH	★★★
Nov. 8	UAB	W	24-17	Nov. 14	Tulane	10. Fisher Leftwich, WR	★★★
Nov. 22	North Texas	L	24-56	Nov. 19	at Temple		
Nov. 29	at South Florida	L	3-52	Nov. 28	Army		
Jan. 2	vs. Texas State #	L	10-41				
#Armed Forces Bowl							*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Scott Abell • Record at School: 5-8 (1 year) • Career Record: 91-60 (14 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Vince Munch • Defensive Coordinator: Jon Kay • Location: Houston, Texas • Stadium: Rice Stadium (47,000)



SOUTH FLORIDA BULLS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 76 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 AMERICAN

OFFENSE First-time head coach Brian Hartline, the former Ohio State offensive coordinator, is best known for producing NFL-level receivers. He has acquired a quartet of wideouts from Power 4 programs, including Tampa Bay Area prep product Bryson Rodgers, who played for him with the Buckeyes. Holdover receiver Mudia Reuben and tight end Wyatt Sullivan will be active as well.

Who will throw the passes? Former 4-star quarterback prospect Michael Van Buren Jr., who started four games for LSU in 2025, figures to be the favorite over Luke Kromenhoek (Mississippi State) and KJ Cooper (Texas Southern). The Bulls will likely rely upon D.J. Crowther (929 yards, 10 touchdowns last season at FCS Dartmouth) and Jason Collins Jr. (1,009 yards in 18 career games at FCS Morgan State) at running back.

USF is projected to have the largest offensive line in school history — with an average size of 6-foot-5, 315 pounds.

DEFENSE The new defensive coordinator is Josh Aldridge, whose East Carolina unit led the American Conference in seven categories last season, including total defense (348.8 yards per game) and scoring defense (20.3 points per game). Aldridge’s defenders have consistent credos: playing fast, making full-speed decisions and creating havoc.

Up front, look for havoc-creating play from a pair of transfers — C.J. Hicks (Ohio State) and Shamar Meikle (Oregon State), who both play the hybrid “Jack” position. At nose tackle, 330-pound Major Dillard (FCS Norfolk State) will demand attention.

There’s playmaking potential with outside linebacker Grayson “Pup” Howard (Florida), a former starter who suffered through an injury-plagued 2025 season, cornerback Za’Quan Bryan (Minnesota) and safety Israel Boyce (West Virginia). Holdover safety Tavin Ward, entering his fourth season as a starter, will provide leadership and stability.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Nico Gramatica was 18-for-24 last season on field-goal attempts, including a 52-yarder (he has five career makes from 50 yards and beyond). Luke Goater (36.2-yard average) will punt, marking the ninth consecutive season the Bulls have used an Australian import.

FINAL ANALYSIS There are new faces galore in the 30th season for USF football — and its final season in Raymond James Stadium. The Bulls will open a \$348.5 million, 35,000-seat on-campus stadium in 2027.

The Bulls get two expected American contenders (Memphis and Tulane) at home while avoiding Navy and North Texas altogether. So Hartline’s Bulls could contend for the program’s first conference title.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*		
Aug. 28	Boise State	W	34-7	Sept. 5	FIU	1.	Dennis King III, LB	★★★★
Sept. 6	at Florida	W	18-16	Sept. 12	at Army	2.	Iverson Garcia-Ponce, DL	★★★★
Sept. 13	at Miami (Fla.)	L	12-49	Sept. 19	Delaware State	3.	Jayson Franklin, RB	★★★★
Sept. 20	South Carolina State	W	63-14	Sept. 26	at Bowling Green	4.	Demetrius Geathers Jr., EDGE	★★★★
Oct. 3	Charlotte	W	54-26	Oct. 3	Temple	5.	Ja’Kyri Watson, CB	★★★★
Oct. 10	at North Texas	W	63-36	Oct. 8	at UTSA	6.	Masiyah Limehouse, CB	★★★★
Oct. 18	Florida Atlantic	W	48-13	Oct. 17	Kent State	7.	Dmari Roberts, WR	★★★★
Oct. 25	at Memphis	L	31-34	Oct. 31	UAB	8.	Lorenzo Barnes, LB	★★★★
Nov. 6	UTSA	W	55-23	Nov. 6	at East Carolina	9.	Jordan Harrison, IDL	★★★★
Nov. 15	at Navy	L	38-41	Nov. 12	Memphis	10.	Derrick Nichols, CB	★★★★
Nov. 22	at UAB	W	48-18	Nov. 21	at Florida Atlantic			
Nov. 29	Rice	W	52-3	Nov. 27	Tulane			
Dec. 17	vs. Old Dominion #	L	10-24					

#Cure Bowl

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Brian Hartline • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinator: Tim Beck
Defensive Coordinator: Josh Aldridge • Location: Tampa, Fla. • Stadium: Raymond James Stadium (69,218)



MUDIA REUBEN

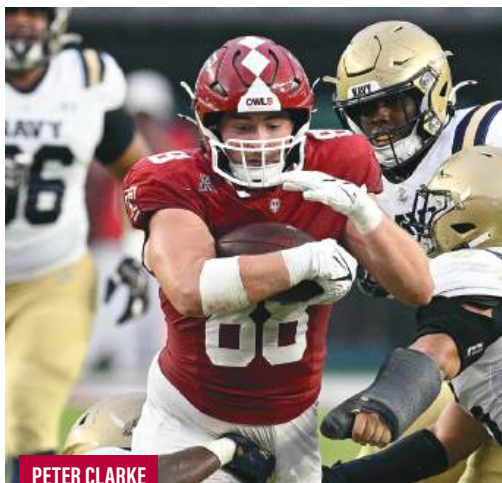
SCOUTING THE BULLS

“With the resources that they have access to and the region of the country that they’re in, you know that it’s always going to be one of the most talented teams in the league. Bringing in a background like [new head coach] Brian Hartline made sense to me. ... [Hartline] is really respected. Recruiting will be at an all-time high there because of the job that he did at Ohio State. What I wonder about is whether all those same great things that allowed him to become a head coach, will those things translate to now being a great head coach? I know that they’re close to spending like a Power 4 program, but they’re not Auburn, or else [previous USF head coach] Alex Golesh might still be there. But they’re not lacking for resources for sure.”

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART			
OFFENSE (2)			
WR	1	Bryson Rodgers* (Jr.)	4 Arhmad Branch* (Jr.)
WR	6	MUDIA REUBEN (SR.)	9 Armani Winfield* (Sr.)
WR	0	Cameron Seldon* (Sr.)	7 Jaron Glover* (Sr.)
LT	77	Michael Wooten* (Sr.)	71 Kahari Finley* (Sr.)
LG	67	THOMAS SHRADER (SR.)	60 Khalil Collins (Fr.)
C	72	Cash Hudson* (Sr.)	55 James Jenkins (Jr.)
RG	78	Caleb Cook* (Sr.)	61 Julius Tate* (So.)
RT	79	Ethan Green* (Sr.)	58 TJ Lawrence (So.)
TE	8	Wyatt Sullivan (Sr.)	85 Kade Caton* (So.)
QB	3	Michael Van Buren Jr.* (Jr.)	17 Luke Kromenhoek* (So.)
RB	5	D.J. Crowther* (Sr.)	2 Jason Collins Jr.* (Jr.)
DEFENSE (1)			
DE	4	Michael Williams II (Sr.)	90 Terrell Jones* (Sr.)
NT	77	Major Dillard* (Sr.)	99 Jahari Grant (Jr.)
DT	11	Asani Redwood* (Sr.)	28 Ryan Jenkins (Jr.)
JACK	1	C.J. Hicks* (Sr.)	10 Shamar Meikle* (Jr.)
MLB	7	Sam Robinson* (So.)	55 Greg Otten (Jr.)
OLB	0	Grayson Howard* (Jr.)	25 Xavier Hamilton (So.)
CB	3	Za’Quan Bryan* (Jr.)	8 Amariyon Fortenberry* (Jr.)
CB	16	Teddy Foster* (Jr.)	29 Deylen Platt (So.)
STAR	5	Ayden Jackson* (Sr.)	15 Tayvion Beasley* (Sr.)
S	9	Israel Boyce* (Jr.)	13 Malcolm Ziglar* (Jr.)
S	2	TAVIN WARD (SR.)	20 A’mon Lane-Ganus* (So.)
SPECIALISTS			
K	7	Nico Gramatica (Jr.)	KR 15 Alvon Isaac (So.)
P	39	Luke Goater (Fr.)	PR 80 Joshua Porter (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



PETER CLARKE

SCOUTING THE OWLS

"[Head coach] K.C. Keeler is a winner. He's done things the right way. I know a lot of people may not agree with some of the things he's done, but he wins. Ultimately, that's what it's about. Getting [12 power-conference transfers] in, especially at a place like Temple, that says a lot because there are schools in the conference that kids are more likely to go to. But [Keeler] is in his home area, and he's been able to put his fingerprints on it. He's gonna have success. ... I wasn't sure how they were going to handle [revenue sharing] at a place like Temple because they're also tenants at Lincoln Financial Field. Obviously, they made a decision to do it, but I don't know how they're getting that because they didn't use to have that kind of money."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	10	Jayce Freeman* (Sr.)	85	Rameir Hardy (So.)
WR	1	COLIN CHASE (SR.)	12	Demonte Greene* (Jr.)
WR	17	JOJO BERMUDEZ (SR.)	86	Reis Stocksdaile* (Sr.)
LT	71	GIAKOBY HILLS (SO.)	55	Kevin Terry (Jr.)
LG	52	ERIC KING (JR.)	51	Mausa Palu (Sr.)
C	57	GRAYSON MAINS (SR.)	76	John Stone* (Jr.)
RG	54	JACKSON PRUITT (SR.)	74	Davray Venu (So.)
RT	75	Luke Watson (Jr.)	70	Zach Aamlund* (Jr.)
TE	88	PETER CLARKE (SR.)	33	Ryder Kusch (So.)
QB	14	Jaxon Smolik* (So.)	13	Ajani Sheppard* (Jr.)
RB	27	Sam Brown V* (Jr.)	26	Keveun Mason (So.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	99	Cameron Jones (So.)	97	Davier Bishop* (Jr.)
DT	98	Joseph Auzenne (Sr.)	58	Kaleb Artis* (Jr.)
DT	93	Kevin Hornbeak* (Sr.)	52	Russell Sykes IV (So.)
EDGE	10	Jaylon Joseph* (Sr.)	56	JaMair Diaz* (Jr.)
LB	22	Eric Stuart (Sr.)	30	Jayvant Brown (Jr.)
LB	33	CURLY ORDOÑEZ (SR.)	44	Tyree Alualu (Jr.)
CB	13	Denzel Chavis (So.)	14	Nakeel Lawrence* (Jr.)
CB	27	Devontae Ward-Grant (Fr.)	32	Adrian Laing (So.)
S	18	Kolin Dinkins* (Sr.)	23	Zyil Powell (Jr.)
S	24	Saboor Karriem* (Sr.)	17	Jaeden Gould* (Sr.)
S	29	AVERY POWELL (SR.)	16	Pooh Lawton (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	98	Carl Hardin (Jr.)	KR	29	Hunter Smith (Sr.)
P	7	Dante Atton (Sr.)	PR	17	JoJo Bermudez (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



TEMPLE OWLS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 90 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 5-7, 3-5 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Temple's offense enters the 2026 season with cautious optimism after showing clear signs of progress a year ago under offensive coordinator Tyler Walker. The biggest question for the Owls will be under center, as they look to replace quarterback Evan Simon. As it stands, the quarterback battle is a two-horse race between Penn State transfer Jaxon Smolik and Washington State transfer Ajani Sheppard, with Smolik appearing to have the edge coming out of spring ball.

Temple returns several key weapons in the passing game, headlined by standout tight end Peter Clarke and veteran receivers Colin Chase and JoJo Bermudez. The ground game will feature a new primary option in Sam Brown V, a Rutgers transfer who impressed throughout the spring as a physical, downhill runner. Perhaps most importantly, the Owls bring back four starters along the offensive line, providing valuable continuity.

DEFENSE The Owls look to pair returning leadership with an influx of new contributors. The strength of the unit lies at linebacker, where Curly Ordonez and Eric Stuart lead a group that brings both production and experience. Ordonez, an All-American Conference honorable mention pick in 2025, is working back from offseason surgery, but once healthy, he and Stuart should provide a steady presence in the middle.

Up front, the Owls will rely on a plethora of new faces. Though unproven, the group has a chance to earn roles early and improve on last season's struggles, when Temple ranked among the nation's worst in rushing defense (197.3 yards per game) and totaled just 16 sacks. Greater consistency and physicality will be key.

Cornerback remains the biggest question mark due to limited experience and depth, while safety stands out as arguably the deepest position group. Illinois transfer Saboor Karriem impressed during the spring with his toughness and athleticism and looks ready to make an immediate impact.

SPECIALISTS Senior punter Dante Atton returns to anchor the unit, while Carl Hardin is set for his second season as the placekicker after converting 11-of-14 field goals and all 40 PATs last year. In the return game, Bermudez flashed elite potential on punt returns a season ago. Kickoff return duties are more of an open competition, but veteran running back Hunter Smith is a strong candidate thanks to his explosiveness in space.

FINAL ANALYSIS Year 2 of the K.C. Keeler era brings a mix of optimism and unfinished business. Despite a disappointing finish that saw the Owls drop their final four games and miss bowl eligibility at 5-7, Temple still exceeded many expectations in 2025. There is real optimism surrounding the program as Temple aims to claim its first winning season since 2019.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 3-5 AMERICAN)

Aug. 30	at UMass	W	42-10
Sept. 6	Howard	W	55-7
Sept. 13	Oklahoma	L	3-42
Sept. 20	at Georgia Tech	L	24-45
Oct. 4	UTSA	W	27-21
Oct. 11	Navy	L	31-32
Oct. 18	at Charlotte	W	49-14
Oct. 25	at Tulsa (ot)	W	38-37
Nov. 1	East Carolina	L	14-45
Nov. 8	at Army	L	13-14
Nov. 22	Tulane	L	13-37
Nov. 28	at North Texas	L	25-52

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	Rhode Island
Sept. 12	Penn State
Sept. 19	at Toledo
Sept. 26	Army
Oct. 3	at South Florida
Oct. 10	UConn
Oct. 17	Charlotte
Oct. 31	at East Carolina
Nov. 7	at Navy
Nov. 14	UAB
Nov. 19	Rice
Nov. 28	at Memphis

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Alex Hanks, S	★★★
2. R.J. Blount, RB	★★★
3. Jude Okeleke, DL	★★★
4. Coen Logan, WR	★★★
5. Antwan Rogers, EDGE	★★★
6. Hunter Watson, WR	★★★
7. Brody Norman, QB	★★★
8. Josh Nengite, EDGE	★★★
9. Daron Harris, ATH	★★★
10. Uyi Igiehon, EDGE	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: K.C. Keeler • Record at School: 5-7 (1 year) • Career Record: 276-119-1 (32 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Tyler Walker • Defensive Coordinator: Brian L. Smith • Location: Philadelphia, Pa. • Stadium: Lincoln Financial Field (67,594)



TULANE GREEN WAVE

NATIONAL FORECAST: 79 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 11-3, 7-1 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Retaining budding star running back Jamauri McClure gives new head coach Will Hall a dynamic playmaker to build around in a loaded backfield. McClure, who was fifth on the depth chart early last season, averaged 98 rushing yards and 6.5 yards per carry in Tulane's final five games while showing an ability to run both inside and outside. Tulane also has Maurice Turner, who won the starting job last preseason before sustaining a high ankle sprain in the opener, and Florida State transfer Jaylin Lucas. Both are versatile runners/receivers who fit Hall's system.

Dual-threat Zeon Chriss-Gremillion, a Houston transfer, and Kadin Semonza, who put up good numbers at Ball State in 2024 but was third string last year at Tulane, will compete for the starting quarterback job in preseason camp. Anthony Brown-Stephens (41 catches, 523 yards, two TDs) and Zycarl Lewis Jr. (24 catches, 330 yards) are the top returning receivers for a group that lost leading wideout Shazz Preston to Indiana but added speedy LSU transfer Destyn Hill.

The lone returning starting lineman, Reese Baker, has moved inside to guard from tackle.

DEFENSE Six of the top 10 tacklers return, a testament to the continuity on a staff that retained key assistants from former head coach Jon Sumrall's tenure. Safety Jack Tchienchou (83 tackles) was the defensive MVP of the American Conference Championship Game. Linebacker Dickson Agu was leading the team in tackles before tearing an ACL in the fifth game. Linebacker Chris Rodgers (80 tackles) returned an interception for a TD in the championship game. Safety Kevin Adams III was fourth on the team with 53 tackles despite never starting.

Although the line lost five stalwarts to Power 4 programs, the Green Wave were incredibly deep up front and should not have a significant drop-off there. Sumrall said several times last season that some of his backups who rarely played were good enough to start elsewhere.

SPECIALISTS Sumrall took both specialists with him to Florida, but transfer Jackson Courville was 26-of-34 on field goals in two years at Ball State (2023-24) and hit a pair from 50-plus yards in 2024. Punting is a concern. The coaches love Lucas' potential on returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS As an assistant, Hall was part of a winning culture at Tulane under Willie Fritz and Sumrall. He put together a top-notch staff and kept far more players than his conference brethren that also lost coaches. If the quarterback play is good enough — a big if — the Green Wave can reach their fifth consecutive league title game.

2025 RESULTS (11-3, 7-1 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Northwestern	W	23-3	Sept. 5	at Duke	1. Jordyn Crites, DL	★★★★
Sept. 6	at South Alabama	W	33-31	Sept. 12	South Alabama	2. Tylan George, IOL	★★★★
Sept. 13	Duke	W	34-27	Sept. 19	at Kansas State	3. Aiden Martin, OT	★★★★
Sept. 20	at Ole Miss	L	10-45	Sept. 26	Southern Miss	4. Cayden Dees, DL	★★★★
Sept. 27	at Tulsa	W	31-14	Oct. 10	at Army	5. Gary Hadley Jr., WR	★★★★
Oct. 9	East Carolina	W	26-19	Oct. 16	Memphis	6. Myrone Jean, S	★★★★
Oct. 18	Army	W	24-17	Oct. 24	UTSA	7. Orion Saunders, CB	★★★★
Oct. 30	at UTSA	L	26-48	Oct. 30	at Charlotte	8. LJ Moton, S	★★★★
Nov. 7	at Memphis	W	38-32	Nov. 7	Tulsa	9. AJ Westfield, DL	★★★★
Nov. 15	Florida Atlantic	W	35-24	Nov. 14	at Rice	10. Nick Witherspoon, DL	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Temple	W	37-13	Nov. 21	North Texas		
Nov. 29	Charlotte	W	27-0	Nov. 27	at South Florida		
Dec. 5	North Texas #	W	34-21				
Dec. 20	at Ole Miss %	L	10-41				
#AAC Championship %CFB Playoff First Round				*Per Rivals			
2025 RESULTS (11-3, 7-1 AMERICAN)				TEAM INFORMATION			
				Head Coach: Will Hall - Record at School: First Season			
				Career Record: 70-50 (9+ seasons) - Offensive Coordinator: Russ Callaway			
				Defensive Coordinators: Tayler Polk, Nate Fuqua - Location: New Orleans, La.			
				Stadium: Yulman Stadium (30,000)			



JACK TCHIENCHOU

SCOUTING THE GREEN WAVE

"The reason why they [promoted Will Hall to head coach after Jon Sumrall's departure for Florida] was because they wanted to have some continuity within that building, and everyone is expecting them to keep trudging on. The success that they've had has been undeniable, so it made sense for them to stick around with something that they know well to try and keep players and coaches intact. ... The thing working for them is that they have enough money to retain the guys that aren't the Darian Mensahs of the world. They have the funds there to be able to prevent guys from leaving for the lower-level Power 4 programs."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	5	ANTHONY BROWN-STEPHENS (SR.)	8	Bredell Richardson* (So.)
WR	15	Zycarl Lewis Jr. (So.)	16	Garrett Mmahat (Sr.)
WR	2	Destyn Hill* (Jr.)	80	Oliver Mitchell Jr. (So.)
LT	55	Dominic Steward (So.)	70	Juelz Baptiste (Fr.)
LG	73	Elijah Baker (So.)	60	Jaxon Ducre (So.)
C	51	John Bock II (Sr.)	60	Gavin Marks (So.)
RG	78	REESE BAKER (SO.)	59	Andre Amos Jr. (Fr.)
RT	58	Ryan Mickow* (Jr.)	52	Tristen Fortenberry (So.)
TE	86	Gabe Lovorn (Fr.)	13	Ty Thompson (Sr.)
QB	9	Zeon Chriss-Gremillion* (Sr.)	3	Kadin Semonza (Jr.)
RB	25	Jamauri McClure (So.)	0	Maurice Turner (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	10	Gerrod Henderson (Sr.)	99	Josh Lewis (Fr.)
DT	45	Ed Smith* (Sr.)	96	Geordan Guidry (So.)
DT	94	Derrick Shepard Jr. (Sr.)	98	PaLanding Drammeh (Fr.)
OLB	48	Jah'rie Garner (Jr.)	40	Warren Roberts Jr. (Fr.)
ILB	2	DICKSON AGU (JR.)	42	Makai Williams (Sr.)
ILB	4	CHRIS RODGERS (SR.)	11	Dalton Hughes* (Sr.)
CB	5	E'ZALIAH SHINE (SO.)	22	Justin Agu* (Sr.)
CB	21	Marquez Stevenson* (Jr.)	9	LJ Green (Jr.)
NB	13	TJ Smith (Sr.)	24	Michael Igbinoghene (Fr.)
S	1	JACK TCHIENCHOU (JR.)	30	Joshua Moore (Jr.)
S	7	Kevin Adams III (Jr.)	27	Chase Green (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	96	Jackson Courville* (Jr.)	KR	12	Jaylin Lucas* (Sr.)
P	34	William Hudlow (Jr.)	PR	12	Jaylin Lucas* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

STEPHEN LEWIS-IMAGN IMAGES



BAYLOR HAYES



TULSA GOLDEN HURRICANE

NATIONAL FORECAST: 108 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 10 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 1-7 AMERICAN

SCOUTING THE HURRICANE

"[Head coach] Tre Lamb is doing what he's supposed to do. He's trying to get people to talk about Tulsa because that's where it starts. I thought them doing the open house deal for the transfer portal was cool. I liked it. He's a young coach, so he's bringing that flavor for the other young coaches who are getting that opportunity. Tulsa is a private university, so for them to do something innovative like that, he's changing that mold over there. ... I know a lot of people that know [Lamb] personally, and everyone has said nothing but great things about that guy. I'm excited to see him continue to try and turn the direction of that program around."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	1	David Wells Jr.* (Jr.)	0	Donnell Gee Jr. (So.)
WR	7	Jimmy Calloway* (Sr.)	19	Grayson Tempest (Sr.)
WR	2	Oran Singleton Jr.* (Sr.)	15	Josh Smith (So.)
LT	77	Brody Duffel (Jr.)	70	Alan Pond* (Jr.)
LG	52	Ian Mayes (So.)	76	Josh Love (So.)
C	66	Will Morris (Jr.)	50	Malachi Preciado* (Sr.)
RG	60	Hunter Erb (Sr.)	51	Javion Antai (Fr.)
RT	73	CAM EAST (SR.)	53	Jack Hood (So.)
TE	84	Jewlyen Roberts (So.)	11	Grant McAtee* (Jr.)
QB	10	BAYLOR HAYES (SO.)	5	Dexter Williams II (Sr.)*
RB	20	Trequan Jones* (Sr.)	23	Seth Davis* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (6)

DL	10	Arias Nash* (Sr.)	32	Hudson Ball (So.)
DL	99	TAI NEWHOUSE (SR.)	88	Dailen Howard* (Sr.)
DL	0	Kyran Duhon* (Jr.)	58	Tyler Rich (Jr.)
DL	15	Thomas Davis* (Sr.)	11	Jaylen George* (Sr.)
LB	6	Chris Thompson Jr. (Sr.)	25	Sam Stone (Fr.)
LB	35	C.J. Turner (Jr.)	33	WILLIAM ALEXANDER (JR.)
CB	3	JD DREW (SR.)	16	Caldra Williford* (Sr.)
CB	7	ELIJAH GREEN (JR.)	13	NuNu Campbell (Sr.)
STAR	2	DEVIN ROBINSON (JR.)	37	Rohon Kazadi* (Fr.)
S	12	Dedaunte Scott (So.)	4	Tyson Williams* (Sr.)
S	1	ZACH WILLIAMS (JR.)	5	Ashton Williams (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	18	Marlon Hauck* (Sr.)	KR	20	Trequan Jones* (Sr.)
P	29	Max Tulen* (Jr.)	PR	2	Oran Singleton Jr.* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

OFFENSE Second-year head coach Tre Lamb is trusting his offense to baby-faced sophomore quarterback Baylor Hayes. Coaches rave about Hayes' "It Factor," something he showed off in Tulsa's 19-12 upset win at Oklahoma State in 2025.

Hayes made nine starts a year ago, including the last six. He threw for 2,158 yards and 12 touchdowns, but it's his running threat (376 yards before sacks) that makes him the right fit for Lamb's offense.

Hayes figures to benefit from a relatively experienced offensive line that features returning starter Cam East at right tackle and six others who combined to appear in 32 games a year ago. But TU must replace its three leading rushers and receivers.

The Hurricane did get a late boost in the portal by signing running back Trequan Jones from Old Dominion. Pro Football Focus had Jones as the third-highest graded transfer RB.

DEFENSE TU's defense was greatly improved in 2025, but an epidemic of big plays plagued the unit as the season progressed. Six players who started last year's season finale against UAB return, led by cornerback Elijah Green, who led the American Conference with five interceptions, and safety Zach Williams, who had 73 tackles and two forced fumbles.

But the Hurricane must fill a huge hole in the middle, as leading tackler Ray Coney (an American-leading 129 stops) moved on to Texas A&M. Linebacker Chris Thompson Jr., a 2025 team captain who missed the season after breaking his ankle during fall camp, returns.

SPECIALISTS TU spent the spring holding auditions at placekicker and punter. Marlon Hauck emerged at kicker after transferring from Mississippi State, where he attempted two extra points and no field goals over four seasons. The Hurricane are hoping to again tap into the Australian punter pipeline after Torquay native Angus Davies started the last three seasons. FCS Bethune-Cookman transfer Max Tulen of Melbourne takes over after averaging 44.6 yards on 44 attempts in 2025.

FINAL ANALYSIS TU earned rave reviews for its "Portal House," an upscale rental home the school used to host staff and recruits during the January transfer window. The team was in need of a feel-good story after a 4-8 record in Lamb's first season — one marked by only marginal progress from 2024. In the end, the real measure of success for the "Portal House" will be the product TU puts on the field. Lamb is confident that he's the right man to take advantage of the American's coaching upheaval. And if a few of those social media stars from the "Portal House" live up to their billing on the field, TU could be a pleasant surprise.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 1-7 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Abilene Christian	W	35-7	Sept. 5	Oklahoma State	1. Jamarcea Plater, RB	★★★★
Sept. 6	at New Mexico State	L	14-21	Sept. 12	at Sam Houston	2. Aaron Edwards, S	★★★★
Sept. 13	Navy	L	23-42	Sept. 19	East Texas A&M	3. Alan Pond, IOL	★★★★
Sept. 19	at Oklahoma State	W	19-12	Sept. 26	at Arkansas	4. Dawson Matthews, OT	★★★★
Sept. 27	Tulane	L	14-31	Oct. 1	North Texas	5. Keynan Farley, CB	★★★★
Oct. 4	at Memphis	L	7-45	Oct. 10	at Navy	6. Deminio Patterson, DL	★★★★
Oct. 16	at East Carolina	L	27-41	Oct. 17	at Rice	7. Carter Langenderfer, S	★★★★
Oct. 25	Temple (ot)	L	37-38	Oct. 23	Army	8. Kadin Fossung, EDGE	★★★★
Nov. 8	at Florida Atlantic	L	21-40	Nov. 7	at Tulane	9. Kyden Barker, QB	★★★★
Nov. 15	Oregon State	W	31-14	Nov. 14	Florida Atlantic	10. Xavier Green, WR	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Army	W	26-25	Nov. 21	Charlotte		
Nov. 29	UAB	L	24-31	Nov. 28	at UTSA		

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Tre Lamb • Record at School: 4-8 (1 year) • Career Record: 31-33 (5+ years) • Offensive Coordinators: Kevin Bar-bay, Ty Darlington • Defensive Coordinator: Josh Reardon • Location: Tulsa, Okla. • Stadium: H.A. Chapman Stadium (30,000)



UAB BLAZERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 121 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 13 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 2-6 AMERICAN

OFFENSE Quarterback Ryder Burton enters his fourth season of college football but his first as the clear-cut starter. The 6-foot-2, 200-pound Utah native threw for 251 yards and three touchdowns while engineering the memorable upset win over Memphis in his first career start. His only other start came in a loss to Rice when he threw for 213 yards and a pair of touchdowns. Look for Burton to take a huge leap this year.

It is helpful that a loaded backfield that includes 6-foot-1, 235-pound Georgia transfer Rod Robinson II can fuel the offense if needed. Injuries slowed Robinson's progression at Georgia, but if he remains healthy, the San Diego native can be a great power runner. Coastal Carolina transfer Ja'Vin Simpkins and ULM transfer Bam McReynolds rushed for a combined 1,228 yards and five touchdowns last year.

Wide receiver depth could be dicey if Kaleb Brown can't come back from a spring ankle injury, but there is some talent there. Tight end Antonio Ferguson is poised for a breakout season.

Depth should be a strength for an offensive line led by returnees Adam Lepkowski and Calib Perez.

DEFENSE Veteran defensive coordinator Todd Grantham has put his stamp on a defense that was quickly rebuilt through the transfer portal. The unit should be strong up the middle with defensive tackles Cam Cunningham, Chris Spencer and Nigel Tate, inside linebackers Muaaz Byard and Ike Esonwune and safeties Jeremiah Jordan and Jotavian Pierce.

Esonwune played in Grantham's system at Oklahoma State last season and contributed 31 tackles. The 6-foot-3, 330-pound Tate was slated to anchor the defense last season but suffered a torn Achilles in fall camp. Delvon Gulley returns at cornerback after an up-and-down season. Marshall transfer Darrell Sweeting could be the best coverage cornerback.

Defensive end Marlin Dean, who began his college career at Georgia and is on his fourth team, is a 6-foot-5, 240-pound presence on the edge. Opposite Dean, Blanche Gold is a bit undersized but is a twitchy, intriguing prospect from FCS Morgan State. Grantham and his defensive staff have also managed to build some depth.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Jonah Delange has made 31-of-38 field goals and all 60 extra-point attempts in two seasons as the team's starter. The only other returning specialist is Owen Simpson, who handles kickoffs.

FINAL ANALYSIS There is a great unknown in Alex Mortensen's first full season as the Blazers' head coach. The program fell into a ditch in Trent Dilfer's three-year tenure. If his team can stay healthy, then Mortensen just might be the coach to get them back on the road.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 2-6 AMERICAN)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	Alabama State	W 52-42	Sept. 5	at Illinois	1. Jayson Moll, RB	★★★
Sept. 6	at Navy	L 24-38	Sept. 12	ULM	2. Malachi Character, LB	★★★
Sept. 13	Akron	W 31-28	Sept. 19	at Louisiana	3. Hudson Higgins, RB	★★★
Sept. 20	at Tennessee	L 24-56	Sept. 25	Navy	4. Mykale Hrabowski, S	★★★
Oct. 4	Army	L 13-31	Oct. 3	Samford	5. Barrett Maddox, OT	★★★
Oct. 11	at Florida Atlantic	L 33-53	Oct. 10	at Memphis	6. Jayden Skelton, WR	★★★
Oct. 18	Memphis	W 31-24	Oct. 15	East Carolina	7. JP Price, CB	★★★
Nov. 1	at UConn	L 19-38	Oct. 31	at South Florida	8. Wes Wiggins, IOL	★★★
Nov. 8	at Rice	L 17-24	Nov. 7	Charlotte	9. Colby Archie, EDGE	★★★
Nov. 15	North Texas	L 24-53	Nov. 14	at Temple	10. Brogan McNab, QB	★★★
Nov. 22	South Florida	L 18-48	Nov. 21	UTSA		
Nov. 29	at Tulsa	W 31-24	Nov. 28	at North Texas		
*Per Rivals						
TEAM INFORMATION						
Head Coach: Alex Mortensen • Record at School: 2-4 (1 year) • Career Record: 2-4 (1 year) • Offensive Coordinator: Alex Mortensen • Defensive Coordinator: Todd Grantham • Location: Birmingham, Ala. • Stadium: Protective Stadium (47,100)						



RYDER BURTON

SCOUTING THE BLAZERS

"It sounded like [former head coach] Trent Dilfer didn't have a ton of respect for the place. Like, he just took it as a job to be a head coach at the college level and never really took a lot of pride in the place itself. The way that he treated people, I heard, was not the best. I know a lot of staff members left there unhappy. Everything I've heard, [new head coach] Alex Mortensen is the opposite of Dilfer. I don't know if that's what was the draw with [Mortensen], but he's a likeable guy who treats people well. ... From what I've been told, [Mortensen] actually wanted that job. It didn't just fall to him. I think he'll do well. It may take a little time to get his fingerprints on it, but he should be fine."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	1	CJ Smith* (Sr.)	9	AJ Johnson (Sr.)
WR	8	Kaleb Brown (Sr.)	6	KJ Daniels* (So.)
WR	0	Ty Mims* (Sr.)	4	EJ Reid* (So.)
LT	51	Payton Kirkland (So.)	77	Keyon Cox* (Jr.)
LG	64	Cooper Young* (Jr.)	66	Donovan Lawrence (So.)
C	68	ADAM LEPKOWSKI (SR.)	69	Kade Martin (So.)
RG	75	CALIB PEREZ (SR.)	74	Barry Walker (So.)
RT	71	Kyrin Mason (Sr.)	55	Barrett Maddox* (Jr.)
TE	85	Antonio Ferguson (Jr.)	44	Scott Isacks* (Sr.)
QB	5	Ryder Burton (Jr.)	16	Nate Rogers (So.)
RB	2	Rod Robinson II* (Jr.)	3	Bam McReynolds* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	7	Blanche Gold* (Sr.)	58	J'Quan Mason (So.)
DT	95	Cam Cunningham* (Sr.)	8	Nigel Tate (Sr.)
DL	90	Chris Spencer* (Sr.)	9	Noah Nelson (Sr.)
DE	5	Marlin Dean* (Sr.)	59	Chris Burge (So.)
ILB	3	Ike Esonwune* (Jr.)	33	Braden Sullivan* (Jr.)
ILB	35	Muaaz Byard* (Sr.)	21	Shaun Myers* (Sr.)
CB	1	Darrell Sweeting* (Jr.)	2	Guylijah Theodule* (Jr.)
CB	5	Delvon Gulley (Jr.)	16	Isaiah Crozier (Jr.)
NB	11	Anta'Veon McKenzie* (So.)	6	Que Billingsley* (Jr.)
S	0	Jotavian Pierce* (So.)	25	Jaylen Thompson* (So.)
S	13	Jeremiah Jordan* (Sr.)	10	Kris Wokomah* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	39	Jonah Delange (Sr.)	KR	6	KJ Daniels* (So.)
P	32	Badger Hargett* (Jr.)	PR	0	Ty Mims* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



OWEN MCCOWN

SCOUTING THE ROADRUNNERS

"They play at a high level week in, week out. [Head coach] Jeff Traylor always has those guys prepared. He's always about the players. He's never going to lose sight that it's always about those kids. Yes, there's been some turnover within the coaching staff, like with [losing offensive coordinator Justin Burke to Kentucky], and yes, that does hurt him because he has real relationships with his coaches. ... I don't know where they're gonna finish within the league because I know that they lost some key players to the portal and to graduation. But with those new guys, I trust [Traylor] to get them to buy in and play at the level that he expects them to."

— An opposing American assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	18	DAVID AMADOR II (JR.)	19	TJ West* (Jr.)
WR	13	Jamel Hardy Jr. (Jr.)	17	James Madison II* (So.)
WR	84	AJ Wilson (Sr.)	15	DJ Allen Jr. (Sr.)
LT	70	DEANDRE MARSHALL (SR.)	75	Jonah Miller (Sr.)
LG	77	Devron Williams Jr. (So.)	66	Davion Hurth (So.)
C	57	BEN RIOS (SR.)	76	Luke Lapeze (Sr.)
RG	74	DARRELL JONES (SR.)	66	Davion Hurth (So.)
RT	71	JAYLEN GARTH (SR.)	73	A'marion Breland (Fr.)
TE	85	Ty Rupe (Fr.)	89	Brandon Young Jr.* (Jr.)
QB	13	OWEN MCCOWN (SR.)	11	Brandon Tennison (Jr.)
RB	11	Will Henderson III (So.)	10	Brandon High Jr.* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	99	TAI LEONARD (SR.)	95	Drenon Fite III* (Sr.)
NT	98	Jameian Buxton (Sr.)	91	Jusiah Sampleton* (Sr.)
DE	19	Johnny Bowens III (So.)	94	Eddy Smith* (So.)
ILB	23	Brandon Tucker (Sr.)	44	Darion White (Sr.)
ILB	13	OWEN PEWEE (SR.)	34	James Walley Jr. (Jr.)
OLB	12	Camron Cooper (Jr.)	32	Elijah Baldwin* (So.)
CB	18	Ahamad Chapman (So.)	17	Asaad Chapman* (Jr.)
CB	24	RJ Lester Jr. (So.)	27	Jakevian Rodgers (Jr.)
NB	10	Archie Chambers* (Jr.)	26	Bryce Grays (Sr.)
S	25	Nate Robinson Jr.* (Jr.)	29	Xavier Walton* (Sr.)
S	22	Elijah Newell (So.)	11	Cam Upshaw Jr. (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	92	Michael Petro (Jr.)	KR	14	Mekhi Anderson (So.)
P	20	Caille Hogan (Jr.)	PR	18	David Amador II (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



UTSA ROADRUNNERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 73 | AMERICAN PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-4 AMERICAN

OFFENSE New offensive coordinator Rick Bowie has designs on pushing UTSA's tempo and unleashing more downfield shots. Quarterback Owen McCown was limited during spring practice as he recovered from surgery to repair a sports hernia, but he enters his third year as a starter with the potential to emerge as one of the top signal-callers in the Group of 6 if he can avoid the injuries that nagged him last season.

Speedy running back Will Henderson III broke out with 866 yards and six touchdowns last season, and the Roadrunners also bring back stand-out receivers David Amador II and AJ Wilson. Running back Brandon High Jr. (Cal) and receivers TJ West (Texas Tech) and James Madison II (Missouri) are expected to be impact transfers. Despite new faces at tight end and left guard, expectations are high for UTSA's offense.

DEFENSE The Roadrunners lost the bulk of their defense to graduation or the transfer portal and spent the spring looking to reload. Inside linebacker Brandon Tucker, a former FCS All-America selection and Southland Conference Defense Player of the Year at East Texas A&M, seems most likely to step in as the leader of the unit after taking a rotational role last season. Veteran Owen Pewee is projected to join him on the inside, making the shift from nickel for his final season.

The Roadrunners have long taken pride in a strong, deep defensive line, and ends Tai Leonard and Johnny Bowens III and nose Jameian Buxton are expected to anchor the unit. UTSA will rely on Camron Cooper — still recovering from a knee injury in last year's opener — to provide a pass-rush threat at outside linebacker alongside UTEP transfer Elijah Baldwin.

FCS Marist transfer Nate Robinson Jr., a San Antonio native, could be a Day 1 starter at safety, while the cornerback position might be manned by a pair of brothers: sophomore Ahamad Chapman and incoming junior-college transfer Asaad Chapman.

SPECIALISTS UTSA returns all of last year's primary options on special teams. Michael Petro connected on 17-of-20 field goals in 2025, while Caille Hogan averaged 45.7 yards per punt. Amador was the leading punt returner, while fellow wideout Mekhi Anderson handled kickoffs, but both spots will likely be open for competition.

FINAL ANALYSIS In the transient world of college football, having a seventh-year head coach in Jeff Traylor and a third-year quarterback in McCown makes UTSA an outlier that will face high expectations. The Roadrunners have posted winning records in every season of Traylor's tenure, and though keeping up with the most well-resourced programs in the American Conference will be daunting, UTSA should remain in the hunt.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-4 AMERICAN)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 30	at Texas A&M	L	24-42	Sept. 5	UTRGV	1. Jarvse Dickerson, S	★★★				
Sept. 6	Texas State	L	36-43	Sept. 12	at Texas State	2. Cael Meisman, WR	★★★				
Sept. 13	Incarnate Word	W	48-20	Sept. 19	at Texas	3. Asaad Chapman, CB	★★★				
Sept. 20	at Colorado State	W	17-16	Sept. 26	Colorado State	4. Jacob Lopez-Veasey, EDGE	★★★				
Oct. 3	at Rice			Oct. 3	at Rice	5. Chris Dupree, WR	★★★				
Oct. 4	at Temple	L	21-27	Oct. 8	South Florida	6. Derek Straughn, CB	★★★				
Oct. 11	Rice	W	61-13	Oct. 17	Navy	7. Mykha Green, RB	★★★				
Oct. 18	at North Texas	L	17-55	Oct. 24	at Tulane	8. Sekope Wallace, OT	★★★				
Oct. 30	Tulane	W	48-26	Nov. 5	at Florida Atlantic	9. Archie Chambers, LB	★★★				
Nov. 6	at South Florida	L	23-55	Nov. 14	North Texas	10. Brandon Brown, LB	★★★				
Nov. 15	at Charlotte	W	28-7	Nov. 21	at UAB		★★★				
Nov. 22	East Carolina	W	58-24	Nov. 28	Tulsa						
Nov. 29	Army	L	24-27								
Dec. 26	vs. FIU #	W	57-20								
#First Responder Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Jeff Traylor • Record at School: 53-26 (6 years)											
Career Record: 53-26 (6 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Rick Bowie											
Defensive Coordinator: Jess Loepp • Location: San Antonio, Texas											
Stadium: Alamodome (64,000)											